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Portugal legend Cristiano Ronaldo hints at retirement, says, 'This is probably my last year of football, I want to leave spectacular legacy', **OTHER BK, P10**

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NTA admits errors, 3 NET tests will be held again

'Misspelt Names, Translation Errors, Factual Mistakes'

Manash.Gohain
@timesofindia.com

New Delhi: National Testing Agency Sunday acknowledged that the June UGC-NET exam papers of English, commerce and sociology had multiple errors and questions were repeated. It has ordered fresh exams for all three subjects. The decision came hours after NTA released the provisional answer keys for 84 of the 87 UGC-NET subjects but withheld the keys for these three papers.

'NO OTHER OPTION'

- In sociology paper, Ritzer appeared as 'Putzer', Parsons as 'Parsow', Ghurye as 'Ghurnye', A R Desai as 'A K Desai'
- In English paper, 67 of 150 questions identical to those in 2024 exam, down to sequence of answer options
- Too many errors, retest only option, admits NTA

The re-tests will be held on Sept 9 and 10. The English exam will be conducted from 9am to noon on Sept 9 and commerce from 3pm to 6pm the same day. The sociology test will be held from 9am to noon on Sept 10. No additional exam fee will be charged.

The testing agency said the three papers had far too many mistakes for the option of dropping questions after the answer-key challenge process to be exercised.

NTA said a committee set up after receiving "several complaints" found "many factual, typographical, translation errors", including misspelt names of prominent scholars, garbled book titles, wrongly worded questions, grammatical and punctuation mistakes and non-standard terms used for established concepts. The committee also found repetition of a "significant number" of questions from the 2024 paper.

► Re-exam won't... P 9

CJI: Never accepted Nalsar invitation, so no question of going

New Delhi: CJI Surya Kant has not accepted the invitation to be chief guest at the convocation of National Academy of Legal Studies and Research (Nalsar) University of Law amid a row sparked by a section of students opposing his presence at the event which snowballed after Bar Council of India jumped in and ordered blackballing of the graduates before retracting with regret, reports **Dhananjay Mahapatra**.

Hours after addressing VCs of national law universities at Jodhpur, CJI Kant told **TOI** he "never consented to Nalsar's invitation" to be chief guest at the convocation.

"The question of me attending the convocation does not arise," CJI said. Four da-

400 OPPOSED INVITE

- Of 1,400-odd Nalsar students, over 400 had opposed CJI Kant as chief guest
- They cited CJI's remarks on a lawyer's plea to take cognisance of 'police excesses' on protesting students
- CJI-led bench is hearing bunch of petitions related to the Jantar Mantar agitation

ys ago, Nalsar confirmed it had, in keeping with tradition, invited CJI Kant to be chief guest at the ceremony that is likely to be held at the end of Aug or in Sept.

► 400 of 1.4K opposed, P 9

5-time TMC MLA, ex-dy speaker dies by suicide in party office

Last Note: 'Never Took Single Paisa, Politics A Mistake'

S Boral | TNN

Rampurhat: Five-time Trinamool Congress MLA and ex-Bengal deputy speaker and minister Asish Banerjee died by suicide inside a party office next to his home at Rampurhat in Birbhum on Sunday, lea-

► Cong neta, lawyer son waylaid, killed in Bengal, P 6

ving a one-page note declaring he "never in my life took a single paisa" as a bribe and regretted giving up a career in teaching for politics.

The 74-year-old had stepped out for his daily morning walk, during which he would

CIVIC BODY LED BY HIM UNDER LENS

➤ Purported suicide note mentions Tarapith Rampurhat Development Authority (TRDA), which Asish Banerjee headed since 2015. 'Other than attending general meeting, I had no responsibility... not on tender committee... didn't have authority to sign cheques'



➤ TRDA under probe since May 4 for alleged financial irregularities and illegal approval of hotels

➤ CM Suwendu Adhikari, who called Banerjee's wife, asks police to check victim's call records to see if 'corrupt individuals from TMC' threatened him

habitually visit the party office, his family said. They grew suspicious when he did not return at his usual time and found the office door locked.

Birbhum SP Vidit Raj Bhundesh said Asish's nephew Abhishek alerted Rampurhat police station after family members peeped through a window and saw what had happened. Police broke

open two locked doors, brought down the hanging body and filed a case of unnatural death. The SP said it appeared, prima facie, to be death by suicide. "No one is responsible for my death," says the purported suicide note in Asish's handwriting. "I have never been involved in any corruption."

► Cops to vet call records, P 9

DOUBLE DELIGHT

Today's issue of **TOI** is organised in two sections, both equally packed with news and analysis. To get the full reading experience of today's edition, make sure you don't miss the other section

OTHER BOOK TOP STORIES

- B'desh sets tough riders for PM Rahman's visit to India
- Construction lapses led to Saket collapse: Police
- In 4 months, UP judge sentenced 22 to death

Biker's throat slit by Chinese manjha on DME

Ghaziabad: A Chinese manjha slit the throat of a 25-year-old delivery agent riding a bike at more than 80kmph on DME on Saturday killing him before he could be wheeled into a hospital, reports **Avishek Kumar**. A Noida resident, Raviraj was travelling towards Ghaziabad in Delhi with his friend Naresh.

► Loses control, P 4

Before Chandra's exit, he & Noel Tata separately briefed govt on rift, concerns

Reeba Zachariah & Sidhartha | TNN

Mumbai/New Delhi: The Tata brass briefed senior govt functionaries on the turmoil inside the conglomerate ahead of N Chandrasekaran's announcement last Wednesday that he would step down as Tata Sons chairman in Feb, people familiar with the matter said.

The engagement covered the rift between Chandrasekaran and Tata Trusts chairman Noel Tata over strategy



Noel Tata & N Chandrasekaran

and governance, the direction of new business ventures, and lingering uncertainty over whether Chandrasekaran would be reappointed, these people said.

Both men engaged with govt leaders individually, though the exact dates and the substance of those conversations could not be independently confirmed. During these engagements, concerns related to some appointments, and the losses incurred by Air India and Tata's digital platforms as well as semiconductor ventures were highlighted.

► See OTHER BOOK, P 9

Slugfest over PC's 'dimagi Naxal' post

New Delhi: PM Modi's 'dimagi Naxal' remark on Aug 15 became the subject of a political slugfest Sunday, with Congress's P Chidambaram saying he was "proud to be a dimagi Naxal" to which BJP replied that the ex-home minister's remark shows how UPA govt was run.

Union minister Kiren Rijiju said the PM was not referring to the opposition. "Only following are Dimagi Naxals: 1. Who support Maoists and reject Indian Constitution. 2. Who stand with separatists & support Article 370. 4. Who want to cut chicken neck to separate North-East from India," he said on X. TNN

► See OTHER BOOK, P 10

Vande row: Shah seeks Sonia apology

Union home minister Amit Shah Sunday demanded an apology from Congress MP Sonia Gandhi, saying she had asked for the recital of 'Vande Mataram' to be stopped midway during Aug 15 celebrations at the party HQ in Delhi. "If Congress functionaries have even a little shame left, they should fold their hands and apologise to the immortal soul of Bankim Babu and to the people," he said.

BJP MLA and Bankim's descendant, Sumitro Chatterjee, wrote to Sonia, expressing anguish over what he called a "shameless repetition of a historical mistake".

Congress denied the charge and called it BJP's "diversionary tactic". P 6

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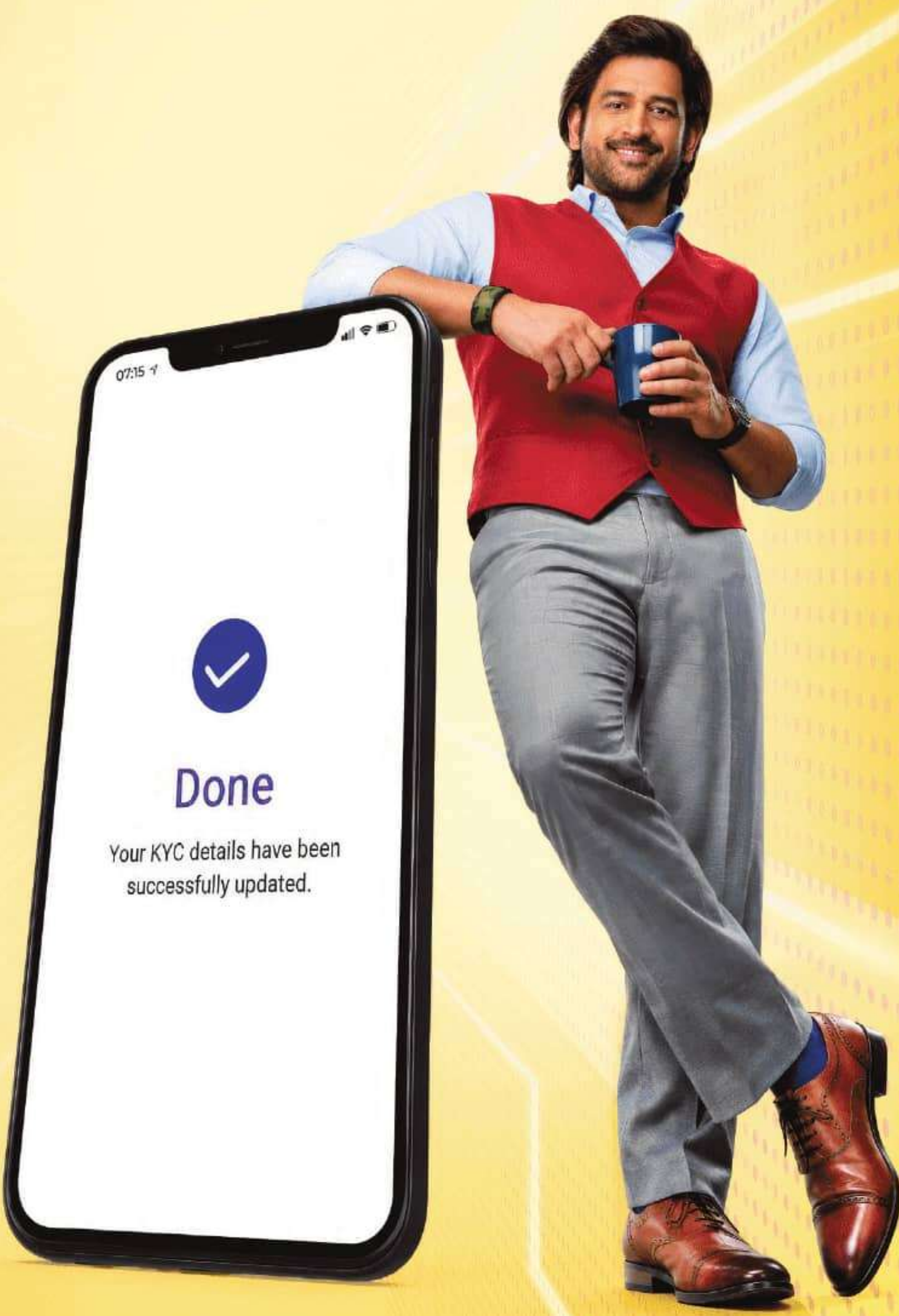


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100 DAYS | PORIBORTON AT A GLANCE

» 100 DAYS OF SHILPO

- ₹54,000+ crore worth investment proposals
- ₹5,000 crore Investment Promotion Framework
- Single-window clearance for investments above ₹100 crore
- ₹100 crore Startup Fund to encourage new ventures and young entrepreneurs

» 100 DAYS OF SUSHASHON

- Anti-Goonda Act brought into force
- Janatar Darbar brings people's grievances directly to the Chief Minister
- Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita and Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam implemented across the State
- Toll-free helpline to report bribery, extortion, illegal toll booths and illicit liquor trade

» 100 DAYS OF SURAKSHA

- 1,000+ acres transferred to the BSF to strengthen border security
- Durga Suraksha Squads and Pink Patrols patrolling streets to ensure women's safety
- Cyber Help Desks in every police station to combat cyber fraud
- Women's Police Stations in every subdivision and Women's Help Centres in every police station

» 100 DAYS OF SAMRIDDHI

- West Bengal's first Atal Incubation Centre (AIC Techno) launched in Kolkata, to nurture young entrepreneurs and startups
- Transparent OBC reservation frame work ensures the annulment of the unlawful 17% reservation and ensuring a fair 7% reservation
- 2 crore+ trees already planted across the state under the Ekti Gaach Mayer Namey initiative
- New airports to come up in Purulia, Balurghat and Malda, with a second greenfield airport underway in Kalyani

» 100 DAYS OF SWASTHO

- Free treatment up to ₹5 lakh under the Mukhyamantri Swasthya Yojana
- 1.43 crore families covered under Ayushman Bharat
- 2,000-bed state-of-the-art hospital coming up in New Town, with 1,000 beds reserved for the underprivileged
- AIIMS and a state-of-the-art cancer hospital in North Bengal, along with modern state-run hospitals in the Sundarbans and Jangalmahal

» 100 DAYS OF SHOSHOKTIKORON

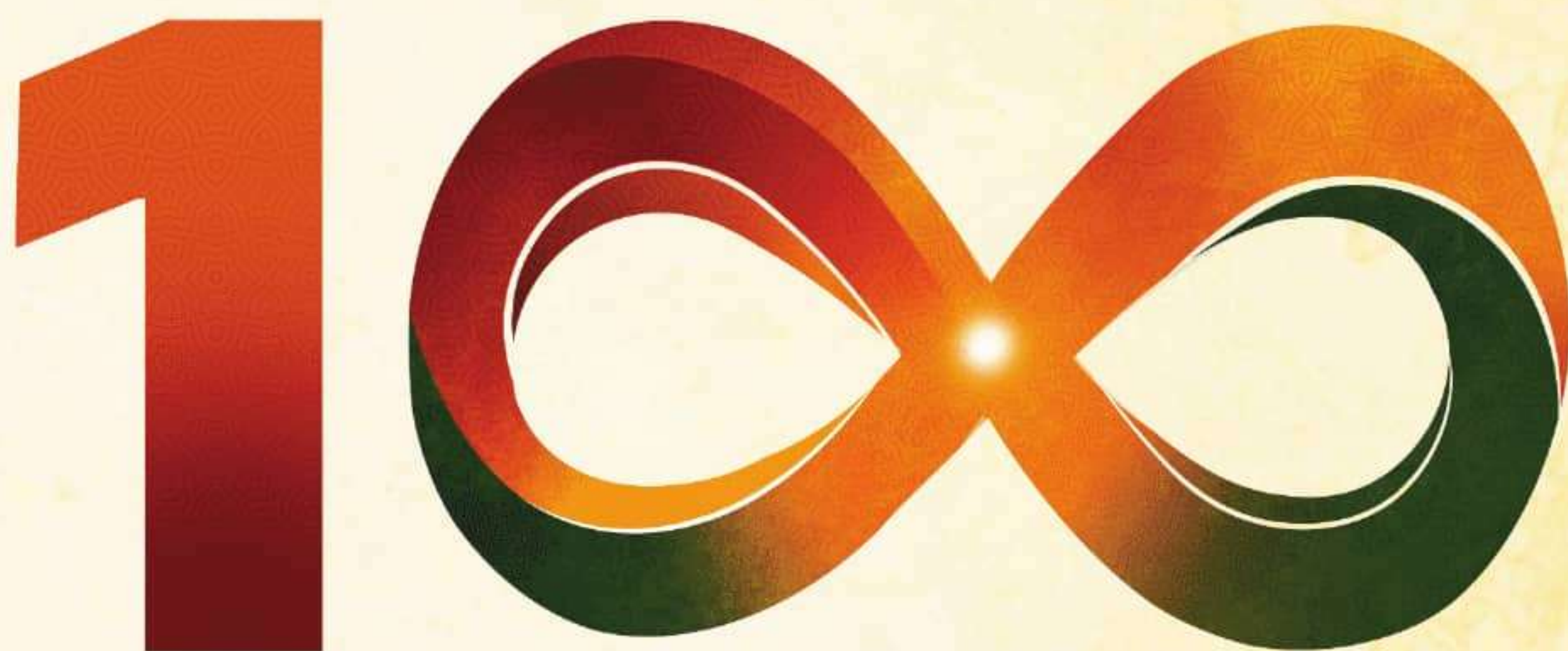
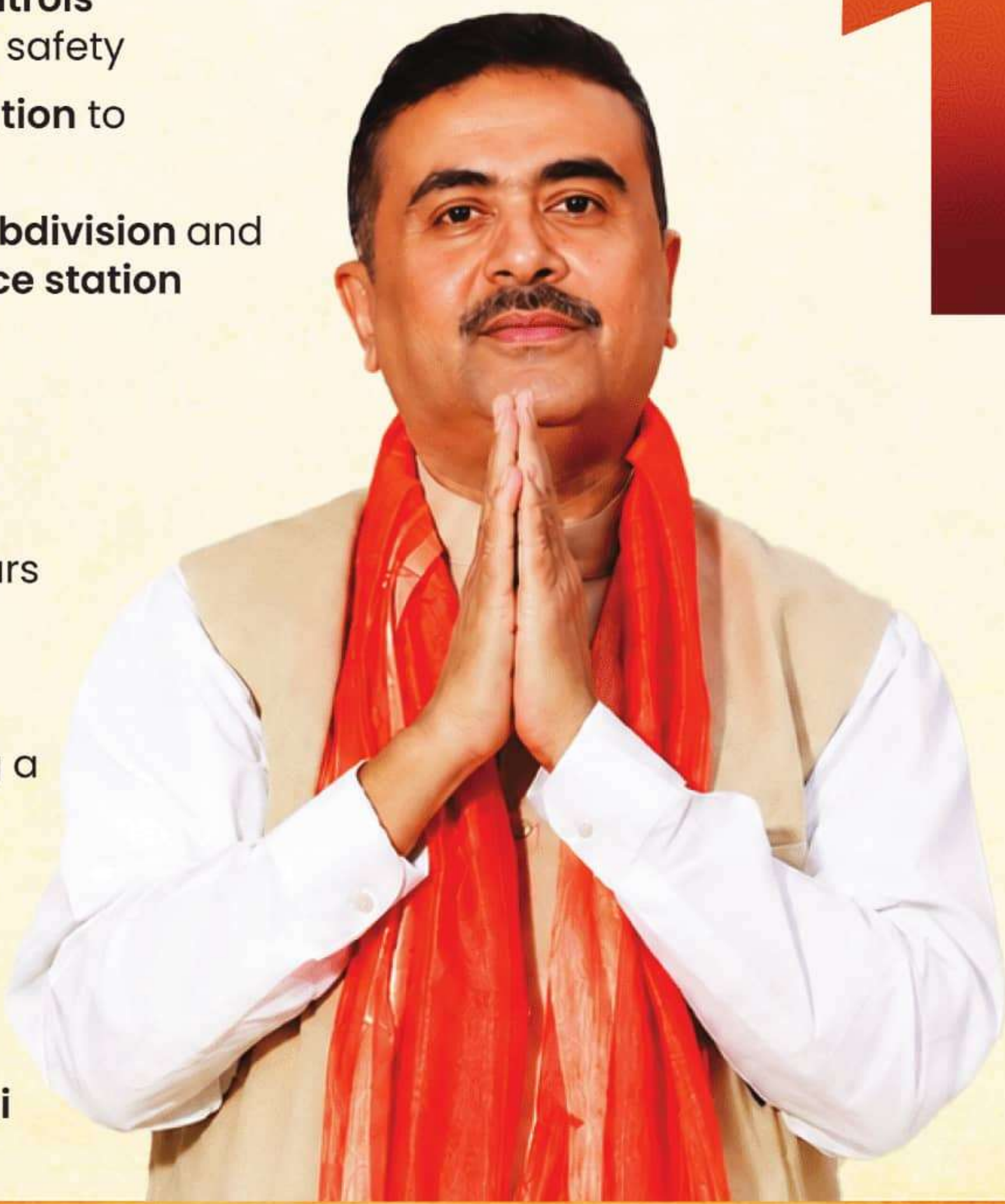
- ₹3,000 monthly credited to the bank accounts of 1.19 crore Annapurna beneficiaries
- Free travel for women on government buses
- To secure the future of the youth, work has already commenced for creating 1 lakh government jobs by the next year
- 33% reservation for women announced in government jobs

» 100 DAYS OF SIKSHA

- Higher Mid-Day Meal allocation and improved food quality in collaboration with ISKCON
- Nearly 35,000 books from libraries across West Bengal made easily accessible online
- ₹296 crore financial assistance to improve government and Bengali-medium schools
- Sanitary napkin vending machines installed in government schools; 10 lakh+ girl students covered under Kanyaratna

» 100 DAYS OF SEVA

- ₹60,000 provided to 10.20 lakh beneficiaries under Awas Yojana
- Fish and rice now served at Maa Ahar canteens
- ₹500 increase in monthly pensions for senior citizens, widows and persons with disabilities
- Daily food allocation for patients in government hospitals increased from ₹56 to ₹110



DAYS OF BHOROSHA

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NEW WEST BENGAL



High court upholds 5-year jail term for teacher over sexual assault | **B2 P2**



TEMP ON SUNDAY
34.4° MAXIMUM
Generally cloudy sky. Max & min temperatures on Monday would be around 34°C and 25°C
27.8° MINIMUM
MOONSET 9.38PM (MON)
SUNSET 6.59PM (MON)
MOONRISE 11.16AM (TUE)
SUNRISE 5.52AM (TUE)



CAG flags unsold DDA flats, land possession lapses | **B2 P2**

Running on empty: Run clubs boom, but urban infra lags behind | **B1 P5**



DJB extends 100% waiver on late payment surcharge on unpaid bills till March

AlokKNMishra
@timesofindia.com

New Delhi: Delhi govt has extended the 100% waiver on late payment surcharge (LPSC) on outstanding water bills for domestic and non-domestic consumers till March 31, 2027, giving consumers the last opportunity to clear their dues without paying the accumulated penalty.

The extension comes after more than 5.2 lakh consumers had availed of the scheme under which DJB waived LPSC worth ₹3,261 crore

The waiver was to end on Aug 15. The extension comes after more than 5.2 lakh consumers had availed themselves of the scheme under which Delhi Jal Board (DJB) waived LPSC worth Rs 3,261 crore. DJB has recovered Rs 815.8 crore as the principal amount from consumers who opted to settle their dues.

The LPSC waiver was introduced by DJB to encourage consumers with long-pending

water bills to clear their outstanding principal dues. Over the years, unpaid bills accumulate substantial late payment surcharges, significantly increasing the settlement amount. Under the scheme, consumers can get the entire LPSC component waived by paying the principal amount. This allows DJB to recover its dues while giving consumers relief from accumulated penalties.

The scheme covers 14.1 lakh domestic and 70,312 commercial consumers.

Water minister Parvash Verma said the extension was aimed at providing consumers with a final opportunity to settle their dues while helping DJB recover its legitimate revenue. "For a family, an old water bill can remain a worry for years. When LPSC keeps getting added, the amount can become difficult to clear. We wanted to give people a genuine opportunity — pay the principal amount and leave the burden of LPSC behind," he said.

"We are not asking people to pay more. We are asking people to pay what they actually owe. If the principal amount is paid, 100% LPSC will be waived," the minister said, adding that this was the last extension.

Delhi sweats, feels-like temp 42.7°C

New Delhi: Delhiites witnessed sultry weather conditions as rain eluded the city. No significant respite is expected in the next few days. The city may receive light to very light rain, but no colour-coded warning has been issued.

The maximum temperature was recorded at 34.4 degrees Celsius, one degree above normal Sunday. The heat index remained high, causing discomfort. It was 40 degrees Celsius at 11.30 am and rose further to 42.7 degrees Celsius at 2.30 pm. The 'feels-like' temperature settled at 45.1 degrees Celsius

at 2.30 pm a day earlier. The day temperature is predicted to stay between 33 and 35 degrees Celsius over the next few days. "No significant change in maximum temperatures is expected during the next seven days," IMD said.

The minimum temperature was recorded at 27.8 degrees Celsius, one notch above normal. It is likely to stay between 24 and 26 degrees Celsius Monday and around 23-25 degrees Celsius Tuesday.

Delhi's air quality continued to remain in satisfactory category with an AQI of 92. **TMN**

WHO RUNS DELHI?

WHERE RESPONSIBILITY IS SHARED, BUT NOT ACCOUNTABILITY

TIMES Special

Delhi has one of the country's most complex administrative structures, where responsibility for a single public issue is often fragmented across multiple authorities. The result: You, the citizen, suffers, but the buck stops nowhere. **Alok KN Mishra** explains

TOO MANY COOKS

A road getting dug up soon after it was constructed is not an unusual site in the city. Unlike any other Indian city, governance in Delhi is divided among the Centre, Delhi govt, Municipal Corporation of Delhi, Delhi Development Authority, New Delhi Municipal Council, Delhi Cantonment Board and several other agencies, with most of these often lacking coordination. This results not only in delays, but also wasteful expenditure of public money. In many cases, even neighbouring states, such as Uttar Pradesh and Haryana, control key infrastructure that directly affects the city's functioning

WHAT A WASTE

The lack of coordination among multiple agencies often results in avoidable duplication of work and also serious inconvenience to the general public. "One agency spends weeks building or resurfacing a road, only for another agency to arrive soon to dig it up for laying a water pipeline, underground power cables, sewer lines or some other underground utility network. Such instances are not a rare sight in Delhi and lead to delays, unwise spending of public money, traffic congestion and inconvenience to residents," said an official who didn't want to be named

SOME EXAMPLES WHERE DELHI FINDS ITS HANDS TIED

MONSOON WOES

In 2023, when parts of the capital were flooded, Delhi faced a major coordination challenge with Haryana, which controls the ITO barrage. Differences over the barrage's maintenance, funding and operation had persisted for years, exposing gaps in coordination between the two govt. Delhi govt has since initiated the process to take over the barrage's operation. Haryana has given in-principle approval, but the transfer is yet to be completed. Another key barrage, Okhla Barrage, located on the Delhi-Uttar Pradesh border, is operated by the Uttar Pradesh Irrigation department. Any decision on its operation requires coordination between Delhi and Uttar Pradesh. Officials said coordination tends to become challenging when different political parties govern Delhi, UP and Haryana

DRAINAGE

Stormwater drains across Delhi are maintained by MCD, PWD, the irrigation and flood control department, DDA and NHAI. During every monsoon season, waterlogging at a single location can involve several agencies because each is responsible only for a particular stretch of the drainage network. Coordination failures often delay remedial action even when the problem is evident

HERITAGE

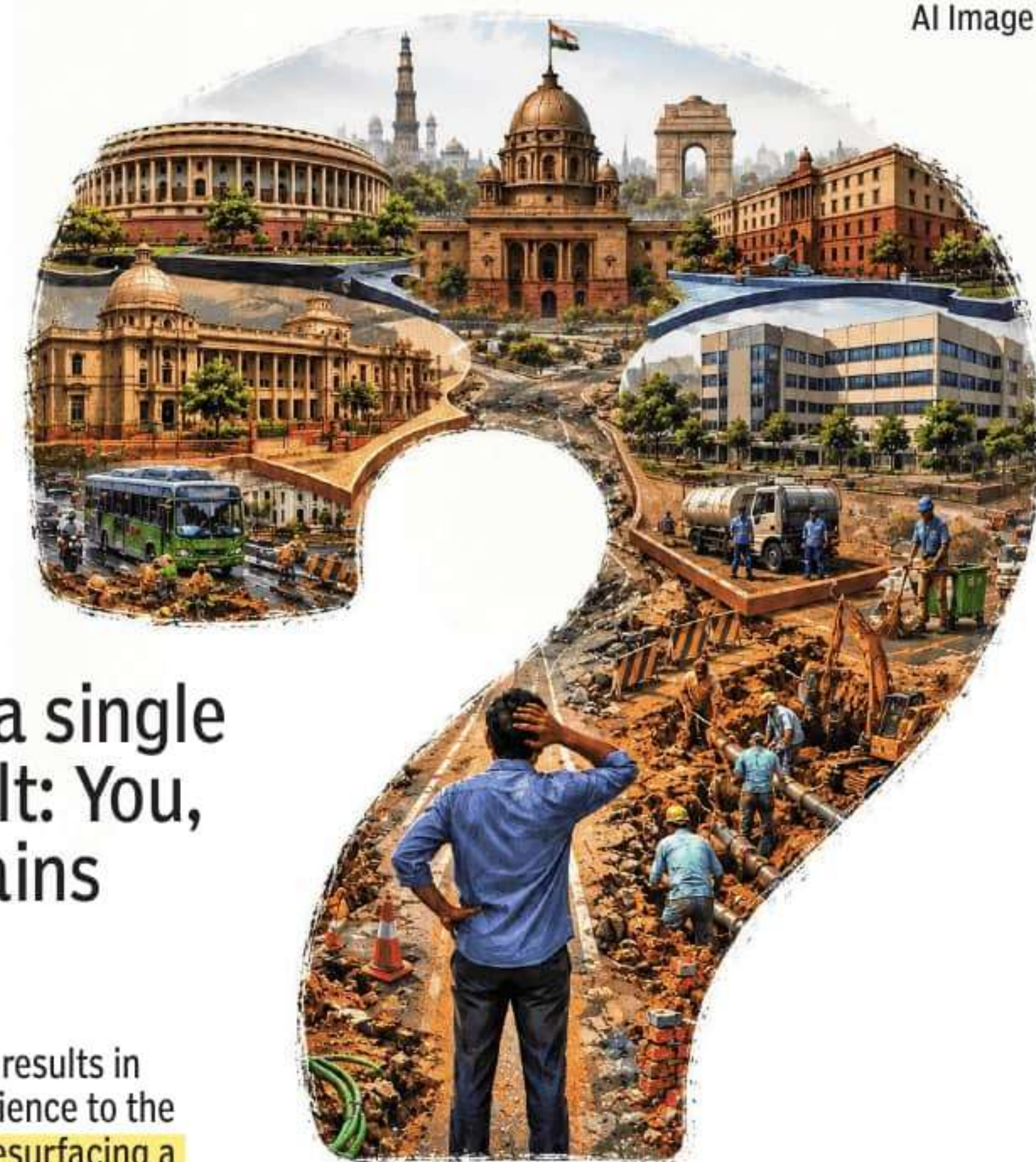
Conservation in areas such as Shahjahanabad involves multiple stakeholders, including Archaeological Survey of India, MCD, DDA, PWD, utility agencies and traffic police, making even relatively simple restoration projects administratively challenging

DRINKING WATER

Delhi's dependence on neighbouring states extends beyond flood management. Much of the capital's drinking water reaches the city through Munak Canal, which is owned and maintained by Haryana as part of the Western Yamuna Canal system. Although Delhi funded the canal's construction which was done by Haryana, the neighbouring state maintains the entire stretch including the 22km stretch passing through the city, and operational control remains with Haryana, underscoring how Delhi's water security depends on inter-state cooperation

ROAD MAINTENANCE

A commuter travelling from south Delhi to central Delhi may unknowingly use roads maintained by Public Works Department, MCD, National Highways Authority of India, NDMC, DDA and Delhi Cantonment Board. A pothole, damaged footpath or malfunctioning streetlight may, therefore, fall under entirely different agencies depending on the exact location



AI Image

DELAYS AND COST OVERRUNS

The overlapping jurisdictions are also one of the key reasons why infrastructure projects frequently miss deadlines. A flyover or elevated road may be executed by PWD but built on land owned by DDA, require tree-felling permission from forest department, shifting of water pipelines by Delhi Jal Board, relocation of electricity cables by power discoms, clearances from railways if a railway crossing is involved, and approvals from NHAI if it interfaces with a national highway. Delays by any one agency can stall the entire project

For residents, however, these jurisdictional boundaries mean little as they expect timely delivery of services, irrespective of which authority is legally responsible. Delhi's governance structure is a product of its unique constitutional position as the India's capital as national and local interests are to be taken into account. It, however, shows that in the capital, responsibility is shared — but accountability is often far harder to locate



While a federal and democratic system necessarily involves multi-level governance to accommodate diversity, the duplication of functions among multiple authorities often undermines administrative efficiency. There is a strong need to rationalise the number of agencies performing overlapping functions, improve coordination and establish clear institutional responsibilities to ensure efficient and timely public service delivery — **K Mahesh**, senior IAS officer and honorary president of Delhi Administration Officers Academic Forum

67% of voters verified, window closes today

AlokKNMishra@timesofindia.com

New Delhi: As many as 47.9 lakh registered voters in Delhi are yet to submit their enumeration forms for the verification and digitisation of their credentials even though just around 24 hours are left before the deadline for submission of forms under the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls ends.

The submission window is scheduled to close Monday night, after which voters who have not submitted their forms will not be able to do so and their names will not be included in the draft electoral roll scheduled to be published on Aug 24.

According to the status report released by the chief electoral officer, Delhi, at 8 pm Sunday, 97.2 lakh of the 1.45 crore enumeration forms distributed across the capital had been verified and digitised, taking the overall rate to 66.9%. The reasons

behind non-submission by so many voters include shifting of voters, death, migration out of Delhi, among others.

It means enumeration forms of nearly 33% voters are yet to be verified and digitised. The enumeration phase began on June 30 during which 13,000 booth-level officers (BLOs) visited door to door to distribute the forms to voters, who were expected to submit their filled enumeration forms to the BLOs before Aug 17.

Election officials clarified that deletion from the draft electoral roll does not mean permanent exclusion. Voters can file claims and objections from Aug 24 to Sept 23, including Form 6 for enrolment at a new address. After verification, eligible voters will be included in the final electoral roll on Oct 27.

The Sunday's SIR report shows that enumeration forms were distributed to all 1.4 crore registered electors, and the distri-

bution rate has reached 100% in all 13 districts. The pace of verification varies significantly across districts, though.

South East Delhi has the lowest rate of 55.9%, with 8.7 lakh of its 15.5 lakh forms digitised. New Delhi follows with 60.6%, while South and Central districts have recorded rates of 61% and 61.8%, respectively.

At the other end, Outer North has the highest digitisation rate at 75.6%, followed by West at 73.1% and South West at 73%. North West and North East have recorded digitisation rates of 70.8% and 70.7%, respectively.

The SIR was extended twice. Originally scheduled to end on July 29, the time for house-to-house enumeration visits by BLOs was first extended to Aug 8 and then to Aug 17. Similarly, the publication of the draft roll, initially scheduled for Aug 5, was first deferred to Aug 17 and then to Aug 24.

Man killed, two injured as DTC bus hits scooter in Najafgarh

New Delhi: A 24-year-old man died, while two others were injured after a DTC bus collided with their scooter in southwest Delhi's Najafgarh Saturday evening.

Sonu, who was riding the scooter, died on the spot. The two pillion riders are undergoing treatment at a nearby hospital.

The accident took place around 6pm on Najafgarh-Nangloi Road. Police said they found a damaged DTC bus and scooter at the spot after receiving information about the incident.

According to police, one of the injured men told investigators that he, Sonu and another friend were travelling from UER-II towards Najafgarh-Nangloi Road when a DTC bus heading towards Kamruddin Nagar hit the two-wheeler. The scooter fell after the impact, and Sonu came under the bus's rear wheel.

The driver stopped the bus a short distance away but fled after a crowd gathered. Locals allegedly pelted the bus with stones and smashed its windows. The conductor and 10-12 passengers were on board at the time.

Police have seized the bus and scooter and registered a case at Baba Haridas Nagar police station. CCTV footage is being analysed to trace the driver. Police are also trying to identify those involved in pelting stones. **TMN**

Manjha forces biker to lose control

► Continued from P1

Around 2pm, a kite string suddenly struck his neck near Media House. As the string cut through his throat, Raviraj lost control of the bike. Naresh grabbed the handle from behind and pulled over.

Passersby rushed a bleeding Raviraj to Max Hospital in Vaishali, but doctors declared him dead on arrival.

The death renewed concerns over the illegal sale of Chinese manjha, a synthetic kite string that is stronger and sharper than ordinary cotton thread. On a high-speed expressway like DME, where vehicles routinely travel above 80kmph, such a string can turn into a near-invisible blade for bikers.

ACP Indrapuram Suryabali Maurya said police received a Dial 112 call about an injured biker lying on the expressway.

"The bike was being driven by Raviraj himself, and Naresh was seated pillion. When they reached Media House near UP Gate, a kite string struck Raviraj's neck. The manjha kept cutting his neck. As the bike was at high speed, it wobbled. Naresh grabbed the handle, controlled it and pulled over. But by then, Raviraj's neck had already been cut," he added.

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APPEAL FOR IDENTIFICATION



General public is hereby informed that this person (depicted in the photo) **Name:** Unknown **S/o:** Unknown **R/o:** Unknown **Age:** 40 years, **Sex:** Male, **Height:** 5 feet, **Face:** Oblong, **Complexion:** Wheatish, **Built:** Slim, **Wearing:** Blue Colour Jeans, was Found dead in front of Ashoka Hotel, Arakasha Road, Nabi Karim, Delhi on **dated 10.08.2026 at 11:58 am** under area of **P.S. Nabi Karim, Delhi**.

In this regard a **DD No.39A dated 10.08.2026**, has been lodged at **P.S. Nabi Karim, Delhi**.

Sincere efforts have been made by local police to trace out information about this person but no clue has come to light so far. Dead Body has been preserved in Mortuary of Lady Hardinge Hospital, New Delhi for 72 Hours. If any person having any information or clue about this person may kindly inform to the following.

SHO

P.S. - Nabi Karim, Delhi

DP/11450/CD/2026

Ph.: +91-8750870428, 9211260428

SEARCH FOR MISSING GIRL



General public is here by informed that this girl (depicted in the Photo) **Named:** Munika Kumari **D/o:** Lal Babu Chaudhary, **R/o:** House No.85, Ganpati Tent House, Tushar Medical Store, Gitori, New Delhi, **Age:** 20 Years, **Height:** 4 feet 10 inch, **Face:** Round, **Complexion:** Fair, **Built:** Medium, **Wearing:** Yellow Colour Suit Salwar, has been missing since **10.08.2026 at about 03:00 pm** from her home

under area of **P.S. Vasant Kunj South, New Delhi**.

In this regard a **FIR No. 499/26, Dated 12.08.2026** has been registered at **P.S. Vasant Kunj South, New Delhi**.

Sincere efforts have been made by local police to trace out information about this missing girl but no clue has come to light so far. Any person having any information or clue about this girl kindly inform to the following.

SHO

P.S. - Vasant Kunj South, New Delhi

E-Mail: cic@cbi.gov.in

Website: <http://cbi.nic.in>

Fax: 011-24368639

Ph: 011-24368638, 24368641

Ph. 011-26139360, 7065036225

DP/11438/SW/2026

What they talk about when they talk about running? Lack of infra

Amin Ali

New Delhi: Every weekend, before the sun is fully up, many Delhi parks and some of its roads fill up with runners. Lodhi Garden, Nehru Park, India Gate and Sanjay Van — places that used to be quiet morning haunts for a handful of joggers — are now packed with groups in matching T-shirts and running shoes, phones strapped to arms, health trackers around wrists and water bottles in hand.

Run clubs have mushroomed across Delhi in the last two years, and what started as a fitness trend now looks like a genuine movement. The problem is, the city's infrastructure hasn't caught up.

Jyotiraditya Thakur, co-founder of Bhag Club, has watched this shift firsthand. When the club was launched two years ago, getting 30 to 40 people out on a Sunday felt like an achievement. "Today, we've crossed one lakh followers on social media, our own running app is live and we regularly gather 500 to 700 runners for a single session," he says.

Smaller run clubs have sprung up across the city, Thakur says, adding that members of such clubs have quietly contributed to building one of the fastest-growing communities in urban India.

In comparison, Bangkok

has parks specifically for runners, with lighting, water stalls, benches and proper crowd management systems, Thakur says. "In Delhi, we're lucky if a park has working streetlights and clean drinking water," he says, adding that runners here would love to have accessible tracks, hydration points, basic medical support for large gatherings and some coordination between park authorities and running communities.

Joel Eric Pinto, co-founder of Knox, speaks of this disconnect. Abroad, he can step out of his hotel and simply run. There are dedicated paths, marked routes, clean toilets and no traffic to dodge. In Del-

hi, that's rarely possible. "We plan for cars, but seldom for runners, cyclists or pedestrians," he says. Cities built for walking and running also help cut down on short car trips and ease pressure on congested roads, he says, adding that such dedicated lanes are public health investments.

Restaurateur and wellness enthusiast Sahil Marwaha has watched Delhi's running scene move from a handful of solo loops in Lodhi Garden and Nehru Park to a citywide movement. But urban planning hasn't factored in the needs of this community, he rues.

He wants future infra to incorporate safer paths, better-maintained parks, police trained to manage runners on the road, hydration points and cleaner air in winter. "Delhi is blessed with greenery, but stuck with poor upkeep of facilities," he says. As more people take their fitness seriously, he believes govt needs to match that shift with real investment.

Amna Ahmed of Adidas Runners makes a case that goes beyond mere convenience. Dedicated lanes, she says, will give runners a predictable, safer space, away from constant conflict with traffic. That safety net matters most especially for beginners, women, older adults and children. "Around the world, cities are recognising running as an essential part of urban life and means of improving public health, mental wellbeing and social connection. As Delhi's running community continues to grow, it's time for our city planning to evolve alongside it," she hopes.

Reeti Sahai, who runs her own running community, Run with Reeti, says thousands regularly turn out at the city's few safe pockets — India Gate, Lodhi Garden, Nehru Park and Sanjay Van — proving that the appetite for running is real. Running lanes need to be part of a city's future planning, she says, adding, "Delhi has the potential to become one of the world's great running hubs, but we need infrastructure that supports this movement. Investing in running-friendly spaces is an investment in a healthier, happier city."



Jyotiraditya Thakur, co-founder of Bhag Club, says when his group started two years ago, getting 30-40 people out on a Sunday felt like an achievement. "Today we've crossed a lakh followers," he says



Reeti Sahai, who runs her own community, says the appetite for running is real



Restaurateur and wellness enthusiast Sahil Marwaha rues urban planning hasn't factored in the needs of the running community

CITY CITY BANG BANG SANTOSH DESAI



The applause was thunderous, the kind reserved for film stars, for the new star on the horizon. For those who haven't heard of him, he is Tukaram Mundhe, Mumbai's new FDA commissioner, who has struck fear in the hearts of Mumbai's eateries by strictly enforcing hygiene norms that have always existed on paper but have never really been enforced. Unlike what we have come to expect, he has started with elite targets, including prestigious clubs and places regarded as institutions in the city, ensuring that the message was clear — no one was exempt. Many establishments have voluntarily shut down for a while to get their act together.

Two things are worth noting here. One is that an honest officer determined to do their job can still find a way to make the system work, at least for a while. The other is that the rapturous response he has received points to something important. People are looking for accountability, and whenever they see a sign that it is possible, they react with great enthusiasm.

Something is changing, as social media is full of people of all ages and backgrounds uploading videos of things that don't work, of officials who are corrupt or ineffective and of the state of our infrastructure. Most notable is the spurt in videos showing young children demanding better schools and infrastructure. There is a visible awakening to the fact that governance is a right and not an occasional favour to be granted as a form of patronage.

There are some who argue against lionising any individual too much. He is just doing his job, they say. And strictly speaking, they are right. Yet we also know that what he is doing is remarkable. Our appreciation is both admiration for the individual and an indictment of the system. The truth is that today competence feels like heroism.

Read along with the surge in people demanding accountability, is it fair to conclude that this is a point of inflex-

ion, when people shed their apathy and their acceptance of whatever reality they are forced to inhabit, and start demanding a new kind of politics?

Before concluding any such thing, it is worth casting our minds back. Through the last few decades, there have always been lone warriors, individuals who have bucked the system and delivered its intent without fear or partiality. We have had our share of bureaucrat-heroes, but no one has been able to usher in sustainable change.

Something is changing, as social media is full of people of all ages and backgrounds uploading videos of things that don't work. There is a visible awakening to the fact that governance is a right and not an occasional favour to be granted as a form of patronage. The truth is that today competence feels like heroism

We had T N Seshan, who, as chief election commissioner, captured the country's imagination by his utter disregard for the powerful. K J Alphons in Kerala became a folk hero and eventually joined politics. Kiran Bedi became a symbol of courage and fired the imagination of many young women. She too eventually joined politics.

The track records of bureaucrats who acquired greater power are mixed. The neat origin story of their rise to fame gets a little clouded by the time we get to the end. Arrogance is one pitfall, personal ambition another. Most commonly, they get neutralised by the system.

The problem is both personal and institutional. The bureaucracy is not designed for fame. It is meant to exercise power behind the scenes for the benefit of the

people it serves. It is meant to do ordinary things well, boringly and predictably. Not as an exception, but as a rule. When fame comes a bureaucrat's way, when their name becomes more important than the position they occupy, it can be destabilising. The feeling might be heady, but it also makes it difficult to stay grounded.

Institutionally, there are enough mechanisms available to contain the damage to the existing arrangement caused by unusually dedicated individuals. Eventually, they can get transferred to the boondocks, to a department where they can cause little harm. The system regroupes as the public need for accountability gets satisfied temporarily, and fundamental change is postponed to another day.

But there is reason to believe that things might be different this time, and it has nothing to do with Mundhe himself, or even with our growing need for accountability. The difference lies in the instruments we have access to today.

In Seshan's time, mass media was that instrument, and it was powerful but necessarily selective. A few media outlets could carry a limited number of stories, which meant the public's hunger for accountability had to be aggregated and centralised. We could focus on a handful of issues that caught the national imagination; systemic change was rarely on the menu.

Today, that instrument of broadcast which was tightly controlled sits in all our pockets. It can record everything at the smallest unit of administration. The terrible condition of rural schools, a bureaucrat asking for a bribe, a policeman misbehaving with the public, a new highway developing potholes can be filmed by whoever happens to encounter it, at no cost, with no institution's permission required.

That is the real change, if it holds. When the demand for accountability becomes a mass movement that makes it impossible for the system to ignore. The anger is against a politics which has created a self-perpetuating system that treats citizens as supplicants rather than those that it is meant to serve. If this pressure grows, that is when we will see real change. Then Tukaram Mundhe can go back to being just another competent officer. For now, he gives us something to be grateful for.

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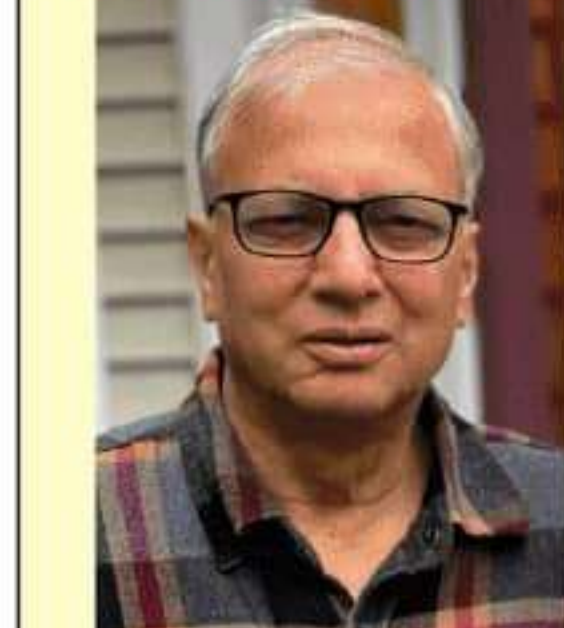
Cops rescue 100kg rare loggerhead sea turtle in Mum

The patrolling team of the Yellow Gate police station, ASI Suresh Bhalerao, ASI Prashant Borse, and PC Nilesh Malusare, found a distressed turtle while patrolling in the territorial waters of the Arabian Sea, reports **Vijay Singh**. The large loggerhead sea turtle, weighing over 100 kg was struggling to swim and float on the surface. The police officials rescued the turtle and brought it on land in their patrolling boat, and further contacted RAWW (Resqink Association for Wildlife Welfare) for further treatment. The turtle was treated and stabilised. The turtle is being shifted to the Sea Turtle Transit Treatment Centre in Palghar district.

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Leopard seen hunting dog near Pune IAF station

A fresh leopard sighting was reported from Lohegaon, 4-5km from the highly sensitive Pune Air Force Station, where another leopard was caught last Dec, reports **Sandip Dighe**. The latest sighting was first reported last Thursday, when a home CCTV showed the leopard hunting a stray dog. Since then, the animal has been seen thrice, officials said, at different locations in the same area. Officials said they've asked an NGO to assist with the capture.

Man dives into river to save disabled youth

A resident of Raigad district, Amol Kadam, swam about 150 metres in the opposite direction to Patalganga river water flow to rescue a 26-year-old cognitively impaired Parbhani youth on Friday, reports **Umesh K Parida**. He was swept away for about 500 metres in the river water. He luckily survived in the water without drowning while being continuously swept away downstream for about half an hour. The youth had been missing since June 2 this year. The search operation was stretched along a kilometre of the river.

'Lizard found' in b'day cake, 7 kids among 11 taken ill

Nalasopara: Eleven people, including seven children and four women, reportedly suffered food poisoning after eating a birthday cake at a party in Nalasopara suburb of Mumbai on Saturday, reports **Suhas Bhirhade**. Three of the children are undergoing treatment in the intensive care unit (ICU). The children later alleged that they found a dead lizard in the cake. FDA officials inspected the cake shop and seized five cakes from the cake shop for testing. "Further action will be taken after the cakes are tested," said FDA assistant commissioner Vyankat Chavan.

TIMES NATION

* THE TIMES OF INDIA, NEW DELHI | MONDAY, AUGUST 17, 2026

BENGAL CM SUVENDU ADHIKARI INVOKES 'GREAT CALCUTTA KILLINGS', CAUTIONS AGAINST 'APPEASEMENT POLITICS'



Sonia sought stop to Vande midway: Shah

Demands Apology To People

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

Jaipur: Union home minister Amit Shah accused Congress MP Sonia Gandhi of asking party president Mallikarjun Kharge to stop the recital of Vande Mataram midway at the party headquarters in New Delhi on Aug 15 and demanded an apology to the people and the song's writer Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay. "Look at Congress's shamelessness. Vande Mataram was being sung at Congress headquarters when Soniaji asked Congress president to stop it midway," Shah alleged Sunday at the Atal Gaurav Smriti Samaroh in Rajasthan's Chittorgarh. "India will not forgive Sonia Gandhi. If Congress functionaries have even a little shame left, they should fold their hands and apologise to the immortal soul of Bankim Babu and to the people," he said. Shah accused Congress of abandoning the national song



If Congress functionaries have even a little shame left, they should fold their hands and apologise to the immortal soul of Bankim Babu and to the people, Shah said at an event in Rajasthan Sunday

Wrong Vande Mataram version played at Jaipur event, BJP apologises

BJP's Jaipur unit was drawn into a controversy after a film version of Vande Mataram was played at a party event in the city instead of Bankim Chandra Chattopadhyay's original, reports **Prasidhi Sharma**. "Vande Mataram" from the 1952 film "Anand Math" was played at the function. Rajya Sabha MP and Rajasthan BJP president Madan Rathore and Jaipur city BJP president Amit Goyal, who were both in attendance, apologised to the audience after the programme. Rathore called the faux pas a "technical error". The admission, however, came only after Congress pointed out the goof-up, with LoP Tikaram Jolly calling it a serious lapse that should never have occurred.

for "vote bank politics" and said PM Narendra Modi had restored its honour. He said Vande Mataram was played from the Red Fort for the first time on Independence Day. Shah's Rajasthan tour, covering Udaipur, Nimbahera in Chittorgarh and Alwar, came days before civic polls are expected to be announced, with BJP combining development announcements with a sharp attack on Congress.

Man assaults delivery agent over 'small' delay, arrested

Rahul.Singh1@timesofindia.com

Meerut: A 22-year-old quick-commerce delivery executive was allegedly assaulted by a customer in Meerut's Ganga Heights society on Friday night after an argument over a delay of a few minutes in delivering an order. The accused, Yaman Kansal, 34, a branch manager with UCO Bank, was arrested on Saturday after the worker filed a complaint and CCTV footage of the incident was widely shared.

The victim, Amit Yadav, said he had been working part-time as a delivery agent for about a year while pursuing his studies. According to him, the dispute began when Kansal called to complain that the order was late. "I told him that the order was delayed by only around five minutes. He argued it was already 15 minutes late. I told him that the reason for the delay would be visible on his app and that I would bring the order as soon as it was packed. He then told me to come to his home and said he would talk to me there," Amit said.

Amit said that when he reached Kansal's flat, the argument escalated. He alleged that Kansal took away his mobile phone, accused him of misbehaving with his wife and threatened to implicate him in a rape case. "He started saying that I had misbehaved with his wife and threatened to implicate me in a rape case. I kept telling him that if I had done anything wrong, he should call police. But no police call was made," Amit alleged.

CCTV footage from the society showed the two men arguing before Kansal allegedly took Amit's phone and slapped and kicked him. The footage also purportedly showed Kansal taking Amit inside the flat, where the assault allegedly continued. Amit further alleged that Kansal threatened to kill him. "I am a student and work part-time in the evening to support myself. A minor delay in an order does not give anyone the right to assault or threaten a delivery worker," he said.

Cong functionary & lawyer son waylaid, killed in West Bengal

Ashis Poddar | TNN

Kolkata: A Congress functionary and his lawyer son were shot and hacked to death within 200m of their home in Nadia, about 120km north of Kolkata, after assailants allegedly blocked their car near a railway crossing and opened fire around 9.30pm Saturday in a suspected case of political rivalry.

Anisur Rahman, 50, and his 24-year-old son Abu Sufian, a lawyer practising at Krishnanagar court, died on the spot from excessive bleeding, police said.

Three people have been arrested, including Trinamool Congress gram panchayat pradhan Fatima Biwi, whose jailed husband Jabbar Sheikh has been named as the alleged mastermind.

CM Suwendu Adhikari said the Nadia SP had informed him Jabbar allegedly organised the killings from prison through his wife and other operatives. "Trinamool operatives committed the murder. The rule of law applies to everyone," he said.

Fatima, Sageb Sheikh and Mithu Sheikh were produced before Krishnanagar court, which remanded them in police custody for nine days.

Bengal Congress president Subhanth Sarkar called the killings pre-planned and politically motivated. On Sunday, the party observed a 'Black Day' in protest. "There is no law and order in Bengal. BJP had promised to restore the rule of law, yet the same network of criminals remains active... A number of panchayat functionaries in Nadia wanted to join Congress and had contacted Anisur Rahman for that purpose. BJP did not want that to happen," Sarkar alleged.

Exact sequence of the killings, number of assailants and rounds fired remain under investigation, according to ASP Surajit Kumar Dey.

Congress functionaries alleged the killings were carried out at Jabbar's behest to gain control of the area. "If the administration conducts a proper and impartial investigation, everything will become crystal clear," party worker Tipu Sultan said. A relative alleged political rivalry was behind Rahman's killing and questioned why his son was targeted. "He stood by everyone in the community. Out of jealousy, his political enemies killed him," he said.

CJP member's dad dies after assault, 8 arrested

Kolkata: The 50-year-old father of a CJP member succumbed to his injuries at Burdwan Medical College and Hospital Saturday night, two days after a mob, allegedly comprising BJP workers, assaulted him twice in Indas area of West Bengal's Bankura district.

Police have arrested eight people, including a BJP worker, following a complaint filed by the victim's wife. "All of them were miscreants and action will be taken as per the law," CM Suwendu Adhikari said on Sunday, adding that BJP had nothing to do with the attack. The deceased Sk Mohammad Mafik's son, Abdul Hafiz, alleged the attackers laid siege to their house for two hours after the assault, delaying Mafik's admission to Idas Hospital. After his father was released from the hospital, the mob followed them, some of them forced the duo into a car, and took them to a deserted place where they were beaten up again, Hafiz told **TOI**. As Mafik's condition deteriorated, the family admitted him to Bardwan Medical College Thursday. TNN

ried out at Jabbar's behest to gain control of the area. "If the administration conducts a proper and impartial investigation, everything will become crystal clear," party worker Tipu Sultan said. A relative alleged political rivalry was behind Rahman's killing and questioned why his son was targeted. "He stood by everyone in the community. Out of jealousy, his political enemies killed him," he said.

Former Congress MP Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury condemned the double murder on social media and demanded an impartial investigation and strict punishment.

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Landslide kills 4 in Arunachal; 5 Army men still missing

Itanagar: Four people were killed and a fifth injured in a landslide on Friday in Upper Subansiri district of Arunachal Pradesh, where five Army personnel remained missing for more than 48 hours after a flash flood swept away shelters at a camp near the LAC in Dibang Valley district Friday evening, officials said.

According to the Upper Subansiri district disaster management officer, the rescue operation after the landslide ended on Saturday after all four bodies were recovered. The survivor sustained injuries and has been referred to Itanagar for advanced treatment, reports **Joken Ete**.

Authorities said NH-77 near Nacho remains under a “red alert” and is closed to traffic because of hazardous conditions.

Meanwhile, at Mipi, the site of flash floods, teams of the Army, ITBP and the district administration have been stationed for recommencing the search and rescue operation for the missing Army personnel after Saturday’s disruption.

Officials said poor mobile connectivity was hampering regular updates from the affected area, located more than 50km from the Dibang Valley district headquarters in Anini.

On Sunday, officials warned of further threats to life from possible flash floods, sudden rises in water levels, unstable slopes, landslides and falling debris in the area.

“Movement of civilians, tourists, visitors and other unauthorised persons towards the affected area is strictly prohibited,” a prohibitory order said.

How Modi has changed focus of I-Day speeches

From Access To Aspiration, Problem To Potential

TIMES NEWS NETWORK

New Delhi: From access to aspiration and from problems to potential — the focus of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s Independence Day speeches has kept changing since 2014.

Those tracking his speeches over the last 12 years have noted how in the initial year, Prime Minister Modi focused on issues such as toilets, bank accounts, poverty and fertiliser shortages. That has given way to attention to priorities like 6G, semiconductor, AI and quantum computing.

If 2014 had mention of toilets as a challenge, Saturday he renewed his pitch for women’s reservation in legislature. “In the early years of Modi govt, the speeches were often about problems that we may today consider ordinary. But PM’s tone was urgent when he addressed them. The challenge was to fix what was broken, reach those who had been left out,” said an official.

As the country has progressed, so has the theme of his speeches, with a constant nudge to move to the next level, while setting the bar high, officials said.

In all his 13 speeches so far, the pitch has always been on taking the country forward and ensuring everyone in society benefits from the gains and the schemes.

“Over the years, his vocabulary began to change. The conversation moved from plugging gaps to building capabilities, from solving immediate problems to creating systems that could prevent those problems from defining India again,” the official added.

In 2014, Prime Minister Modi called for eradicating poverty. Over the years, the focus has shifted to building a developed nation as poverty levels fell and crores moved out of extreme poverty.

So, in Prime Minister Modi’s 2026 speech, he underlined how social security cover has seen a four-fold jump to 100 crore citizens in the last 12 years.

Women have remained a prominent theme over the past 12 years.

12 YEARS OF PM’S I-DAY PITCHES

2014 Toilets to ensure dignity of women, emphasis on poverty eradication, need to end farmer suicides	2024 Keen interest among school kids due to Chandrayaan launch
2015 Announces Startup India, Standup India	2025 Preparing for launch of Aatmanirbhar Bharat, Gaganyaan, space station
2016 Pucca roads, especially in rural areas, something that every citizen in the country craves for	2026 Thrust on AI, quantum computing, chips to position India as innovation hub; calls for startups in every block; reservation for women in legislatures; farmers should tap global markets via FTAs
2018 Over 100 satellite launches by Indian scientists, leaving the world astonished; ensured MSP that was 1.5 times the cost	

As the country has progressed, so has the theme of PM Narendra Modi’s speeches, with a constant nudge to move to the next level, while setting the bar high, officials said. In all his 13 speeches so far, the pitch has always been on taking the country forward and ensuring everyone in society benefits from the gains and the schemes

ing systems that could prevent those problems from defining India again,” the official added.

In 2014, Prime Minister Modi called for eradicating poverty. Over the years, the focus has shifted to building a developed nation as poverty levels fell and crores moved out of extreme poverty.

So, in Prime Minister Modi’s 2026 speech, he underlined how social security cover has seen a four-fold jump to 100 crore citizens in the last 12 years.

Women have remained a prominent theme over the past 12 years.

HC: Elder child gets priority over siblings for compassionate job

Partha.Behera
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Raipur: When multiple eligible children claim a compassionate appointment, the elder child must receive priority based on seniority, Chhattisgarh high court has ruled. Justice Sanjay K Agrawal on Aug 8 set aside an order issued by Mungeli district education officer (DEO) appointing the younger son of a deceased govt servant on compassionate grounds.

The court remitted the matter back to the DEO, ordering the officer to consider the elder son’s claim within 30 days after examining his eligibility.

Ishwar Singh Kshatriya, a peon at Govt Higher Secondary School in Mungeli’s Dharampura, died on Sept 29, 2016. He had two wives. Jitendra Singh Kshatriya, 35, born to Ishwar’s first wife, and Rajkumar, born to his second wife, both applied for the relief job. The DEO chose Rajkumar for the job on Aug 7, 2019, prompting Jitendra to move the high court.

The court observed that while a child born from a second marriage remains a legitimate heir for dependent employment benefits, the state govt guidelines remain silent on choosing from among multiple siblings.

Relying on precedents set by Patna high court in Raj Kishore Kumar vs State of Bihar and followed by Jharkhand high court, Justice Agrawal held that entitlement to a compassionate appointment must follow seniority.

Seniority alone doesn’t give govt employee right to higher post: HC

Raipur: Seniority alone does not give a govt employee the automatic right to claim charge of a higher post, the Chhattisgarh high court has ruled while dismissing a writ petition filed by a block education officer (BEO) challenging the appointment of a junior colleague as the in-charge district education officer (DEO). Justice Bibhu Datta Guru, in his Aug 11 order, upheld the state govt’s decision to assign the current charge of Gariaband DEO post to Rajesh Chandrakar, rejecting the plea of Kishun Lal Matawale, the BEO of Chhura.

Matawale had challenged the June 10 govt order, arguing he was senior to Chandrakar in the cadre and possessed the requisite qualifying service under the Chhattisgarh School Education Services Rules, 2026. The petitioner said he had submitted a representation on July 20, 2026, which remained unaddressed. The state govt argued that Matawale substantively held the post of a principal and was merely performing duties as in-charge BEO, reports **Partha Behera**.

It also informed the court that Gariaband collector had sent a communication on June 6, 2025, noting gross negligence and violation of govt rules by Matawale.

The court observed that temporary entrustment of charge is a stopgap arrangement that requires an assessment of administrative suitability and overall record, where seniority cannot act as a sole determining factor.

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by Patna high court in Raj Kishore Kumar vs State of Bihar and followed by Jharkhand high court, Justice Agrawal held that entitlement to a compassionate appointment must follow seniority.

ITBP DIG, driver killed in SUV crash

Meerut: An Indo-Tibetan Border Police (ITBP) deputy inspector general (DIG) and his driver were killed while four others, including the officer’s gunner, were injured after his SUV collided with a car on the Dehradun-Panchkula national highway in UP’s Saharanpur Saturday.

DIG Parminder Singh, 52, posted in Srinagar, was returning to Ambala after completing training in Mussoorie when the accident occurred around 9am near Jhabiran Cut under Sarsawa police station, reports **Rahul Singh**. Officials said the SUV went out of control, hit the central divider and crossed into the opposite lane, where it collided with a sedan.

The impact trapped occupants of both vehicles inside. Police teams rescued the injured and shifted them to Govt Medical College at Pilkhahi.

Doctors declared Singh and his driver, Ravi Shankar, dead on arrival. The DIG’s gunner, Jayram suffered serious injuries. Three occupants of the sedan — Gurunak Singh, 49, Gurnam Singh, 55, and Devendra Kaur, 55 — were also injured.

Navy sailor, wife, 2 kids found dead in Mum residence, police suspect murder-suicide

Ahmed.Ali@timesofindia.com

Mumbai: A 30-year-old Indian Navy sailor and his wife and two children were found dead in their Navy quarters at Navy Nagar in south Mumbai’s Cuffe Parade Saturday night. According to preliminary information, investigators suspect that Purnamal Shambhulal Mehra died by suicide.

Prima facie findings indicate that poisoning may have caused the death of his wife Oma (28), three-year-old son Darsh, and two-month-old daughter, although officials stressed that the exact cause of death can only be determined after detailed forensic and post-mortem reports are received.

The family hailed from Rajasthan.

Purnamal’s younger brother, who is also serving in the Indian Navy posted on the outskirts of the city, arrived in Mumbai to claim the bodies from J J Hospital.

According to police, Purnamal’s father tried to contact him at night, but when his calls went unanswered, he got worried and alerted the Navy’s control room.



Prima facie findings indicate that poisoning may have caused the death of Mehra’s wife Oma (28), three-year-old son Darsh, and two-month-old daughter

Naval officials reached the Mehra’s quarters and found Purnamal dead in the living room and the bodies of his wife and children in a bedroom. The officials then informed Cuffe Parade police.

The bodies were shifted to J J Hospital, where all four were declared dead.

A forensic science laboratory team collected evidence from the scene. Police said they found no suicide note or

suspicious substance during a search of the house.

During preliminary questioning of neighbours and persons known to the family, police learnt that the couple, who had been married for four to five years, allegedly had marital discord and frequently quarrelled.

“A week ago, Oma’s father had come to Mumbai to take her back home. However, Purnamal reportedly refused and told him that if she wished to leave she could do so, but he would not allow the children to go with her. We will enquire what was the reason behind the couple’s infighting,” a police officer said.

Police have registered an Accidental Death Report.

FDA notice to SRK, Tiger Shroff & Ajay Devgn for Vimal Elaichi ad

Mumbai: FDA has issued a formal show-cause notice to Shah Rukh Khan, Tiger Shroff, and Ajay Devgn for their role in the advertisement of the Vimal Elaichi brand, alleging that this is masked to promote Vimal Pan Masala, which is banned in the state for causing oral cancer.

The notice states that the ad is in circulation via YouTube and allied media platforms. “In the said advertisement, the expression ‘Vimal Elaichi’ is used in a manner which appears to create an association with the Vimal Pan Masala brand prevalent in Maharashtra, and may thereby mislead consumers and indirectly promote the brand identity of the prohibited product,” the notice reads.

Dr Pankaj Chaturvedi, director of the Advanced Centre for Treatment, Research & Education in Cancer, who has long campaigned against tobacco use and called for tighter regulation, said, “We have tried multiple times to approach these Bollywood actors who have made huge profits out of these products and caused mass addiction. These are youth icons, their actions translate into direct sales. Tobacco companies are not paying them out of charity.”

The administration added that Vimal Pan Masala is a product prohibited for manufacture, storage, transportation, distribution, and sale in the state under a Prohibition Order issued by FDA commissioner Tukaram Mundhe. According to the notice, the advertisements violate the sections under the Food Safety and Standards Act, 2006, as well as advertisement regulations, and COTPA Act. **TNN**

Dipke & Co now start drive to ‘fix’ state-run schools

Prasad Joshi & Suparna Roy

Chhatrapati Sambhaji-nagar/Jaipur: Cockroach Janta Party founder Abhijeet Dipke Sunday demanded immediate suspension of a govt school principal over alleged alcoholism in Maharashtra, while his colleagues in Rajasthan announced an “inspection” of state-run schools as part of CJP’s “*School Thik Karo* (fix the schools)” campaign.

Dipke led the drive himself in Maharashtra, visiting the zilla parishad school in Limbala village of Hingoli district following complaints from villagers against the principal.

“The principal must be suspended immediately. This is a serious safety concern for the children, especially little girls,” Dipke wrote on social media, sharing videos purportedly showing the principal with liquor bottles and sleeping inside class. Dipke warned he would join villagers in protests from Tuesday if corrective measures were not initiated.

Hingoli Zilla Parishad CEO Vivek Gaikwad promised an inquiry and a visit to the school by a block education officer-led committee Monday. Gaikwad claimed, however, that the videos shared by Dipke were old. “When the videos surfaced last year, the principal was reprimanded,” the officer said.

In Rajasthan, CJP national spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka said they had received requests to inspect unsafe or poorly maintained schools from nine districts.

Rahul’s Pune rally will be exclusively for girls

New Delhi: As part of his “chhatron ki goonj” meetings targeting the youth, Congress’s Rahul Gandhi said the upcoming rally in Pune on Aug 22 will be exclusively for girls.

The announcement came along with Rahul’s social media video post featuring an interaction with some Jantar Mantar protesters. Rahul said, “The courage with which India’s youngsters have stood firm against PM Modi’s violent regime, demanding accountability, is commendable.” He added, “I am proud of every single young person — especially the girls who faced the BJP goons’ misbehaviour, verbal abuse and violence, even being forced to apologise to the Prime Minister.”

Announcing the Pune meeting, Rahul said, “But now their (girls’) voices cannot be silenced. On Aug 22, Chhatron ki goonj is arriving in Pune — and this time, the event will be exclusively for girls. Now the girls will speak, and the country will listen.” **TNN**

INDIA DIGEST

Chamoli tunnel disaster: Death toll rises to 8

One more body was recovered Saturday from the under-construction tunnel at THDC India Limited’s hydropower project site in Mayapur, Chamoli district, taking the death toll in the tunnel disaster to eight. The victim was identified as Devnath Baghel, a resident of Chhattisgarh. Two workers remain missing as a multi-agency search and rescue operation continues.

Two killed, 8 hurt in Maha gas leak

Two industrial workers, Amit Kumar (28) and Kalpesh Vandre (31), died of suffocation after being exposed to toxic gases that leaked from a reactor of a chemical manufacturing company, Indo Amines Ltd, in Mahad MIDC, Raigad Saturday evening. Eight others including an 11-year-old girl suffered serious suffocation. At least 40 persons were exposed to the leaked gas.

4 held for ‘death threat’ to Himanta

Police Sunday arrested four people in Assam’s Morigaon district for allegedly posting a death threat against state chief minister Himanta Biswa Sarma during his Facebook Live broadcast of the Independence Day speech. The accused were identified as Abdul Mutaleb, his father, brother and one Rashidul Islam. According to police, the comment was posted from an account bearing Mutaleb’s name.

ੴ ANTIM ARDAS ੴ



With profound grief and sorrow,
we announce the sad demise of our beloved
Swaranjit Singh Kohli
(S/o Late Sardar Avtar Singh Kohli)

Antim Ardas
will be held on Tuesday,
18th August 2026, 4:00 pm to 5:00 pm
Followed by LANGAR
at Pahadiwala Gurdwara, Greater Kailash - I, New Delhi

In Grief:
Priya & Gogi Kohli
Bandana & Pankaj Bajaj
Simranjit & Mansimran Kohli
Jaibir, Johann, Kairav, Siffat, Deetya, Kuval
Kohlis, Chhabras, Bajajs, Anands

B - 11, Greater Kailash Part - I, New Delhi



CONTRAPUNTO

For men may come and men may go,
But I go on forever
— TENNYSON, *The Brook*

Cry Me A River

In retreat, Rhine and Danube are exposing Europe's past. But also a future where the world's parched

Some crises are 'best' seen from space, others up close and personal. Europe's drying rivers look scary both ways. Satellites show dramatically shrunk waterways, things feel extraordinary at individual eye level too. People are walking where they kayaked all their life. Record low water levels have laid bare sunken Nazi ships, an unexploded 700kg British bomb, centuries-old "hunger stones", even the remains of an ancient mammoth. As if the retreating rivers are exposing Europe's past, alongside a frightening future.

Rhine, Danube, Elbe...are also shipping lanes, industrial cooling systems, agri grid, sources of drinking water and energy. They are continental infra. As Europe's relics meet a harsh sun, so do the assumptions beneath its prosperity. Turns out rainfall, rivers, groundwater, fertile fields...are not permanent geography but variable ecological phenomena. When world leadership pretty much binned the 1.5°C goalpost to head towards 2°C above pre-industrial levels, it was never going to be without consequences. And for all the fear factor of dried rivers, the groundwater story that people cannot see may be worse. Obviously, none of this is a Europe-only problem.

It's no longer about one drought year, but about grim goings-on even in good rain years. University College London scientists have used satellite data to show that vast swathes of Europe's water reserves have gotten depleted between 2002-24. Similar red flags abound in India. 2025's Dynamic Groundwater Resources Assessment found the national extraction rate at 61% of assessed recharge. But there are huge regional differences, where many areas are beyond the 70% threshold, considered a critical limit for sustainable usage. A Punjab Agricultural University study reports, tellingly, that between 1998-2005 the state's average pre-monsoon water table has dropped from 7.8m below ground level to 21m.

A do-nothing lot are always harking on the cost of solutions. Consider that many of India's water-parched cities are coastal. So, investing in desalination now, no matter how expensive, like Chennai is doing, makes more sense than leaving it to zero-water day. Where we should get serious about counting costs is how a "development" project impacts the water ecosystem, and greenlight it only if it comes out blue at the end. Europe to India, we can no longer assume that any of our water supply is "permanent". That means we have to effectively build a second water system to keep the one that Nature gave us alive. We have to "make" water from the sea, sewage, wastewater. And when we get rain, we have to catch it before it runs away.

Whose War Is It?

Both Iran and Ukraine show war is still old people talking & young men dying

The extended deployment at sea of American aircraft carrier USS Abraham Lincoln has not just exposed the logistical challenges of US's war against Iran, but ugly realities of war itself. The Lincoln has been almost nine months at sea, and is about to break the record for the longest trip away from home port for a US carrier since Vietnam War. That record was set by another ship, USS Gerald R Ford, just months ago. Reports have surfaced of low crew morale and even suicidal tendencies among crewmen on the Lincoln, with family members of the deployed navymen lambasting the military leadership.

The Lincoln's predicament exemplifies the manner in which US has carried out this war – without any clarity and constantly shifting goalposts. This has completely messed up logistics, and left navymen and their families in limbo. Naturally, the psychological pressure is immense – an open-ended war, combined with no port calls for months will lead to serious mental health issues. No wonder two sailors on the Lincoln jumped overboard in recent months. But Trump has batted away criticism. Which isn't surprising. War, after all, is old men talking, and young men dying. It is this realisation that galvanised anti-war protests during Vietnam, finally compelling Washington to hightail it from that theatre.

But old people in power never learn. Whether Trump with Iran, or Putin with Ukraine, they continue to send young men to die to satisfy their own egos. But, in this hyperconnected world, it is slowly becoming difficult for the high and mighty to constantly pull the wool over people's eyes. Trump's approval ratings have plummeted following the Iran war. Putin recently banned the only anti-war party, Yabloko, from upcoming parliamentary polls in Russia. Internal resentment will only grow if young men continue to die in senseless wars. Old folks in authority must course-correct, or face trouble.

Cheques and balances

Some of us will miss that piece of paper

Jug Suraiya

It was a small rectangle of paper, perhaps six inches by three. I gazed at it with reverence due to a priceless work of art. It wasn't a work of art, but for me it was priceless. It was the first cheque I'd ever received, for the princely sum of ₹300, which was my first month's salary as a feature writer for the *Junior Statesman*, the youth magazine that *The Statesman* newspaper was launching.

The avuncular Company Secretary, PT Dastoor, took me to Accounts Department, where a Chatterjee Babu guided me through the intricacies of opening a bank account and obtaining a cheque book of my own.

That cheque was a milestone in the journey of my life, representing transition from feckless youth to gainfully employed adult.

I recalled my first cheque, and the transformative impression it made on me, when I read a recent press report that cheques as instruments of commercial negotiation are being phased out by more up-to-date forms of give and take, such as credit and debit cards, digital payment platforms, and bank transfers.

An endangered species, cheques now generally provide photo ops when outsized examples of them, denoting very large amounts, are ceremoniously handed over for commercial or charitable purposes.

The increasing disappearance of cheques in relation to bank balances has its advantages, mainly those of transactional rapidity.

Cheques could involve time-consuming procedures, particularly when withdrawing money. You handed the cheque to a cashier who gave you a numbered brass token that you clutched in your hand while waiting for your number to be called, doing time-pass chitchat with fellow waitees, also holding brass tokens. Instant-use ATMs have replaced brass tokens, but aren't given to time-pass chitchat.

Cheques have a chequered history that now draws to a close, and have been part and parcel of our own annals, our personal rites of passage. And, in hindsight, I wonder if that first cheque of mine was perhaps not a work of art, but at least a piece of memorabilia worthy of being framed and put on the wall as a portrait of the writer as a newfound man.

Gold-Rich, Capital-Starved

India would have a current account surplus if it didn't import gold as hungrily as it does. We have some 35,000 tonnes of it. Here are four ideas to convert this cache into liquidity and strategic strength

Nilesh Shah

India sits on a conservatively estimated 35,000 tonnes of gold, valued at well over 115% of GDP. We are the only country in the world with this distinction, yet we behave like Kasturi Mrig – the musk deer that searches frantically for a scent that lies within itself. We chase external capital through FDI, FPI, and borrowings like FCNR B deposits, while the real treasure remains frozen in our own *tijoris*.

This paradox has turned gold from a cultural and valuable asset into a vulnerability. Over the past eight years, India's cumulative current account deficit stood at approximately \$251bn. Gross gold imports during the same period reached \$353bn.

When we add net imports of silver, pearls, diamonds, smuggled gold, and the gold jewellery travellers bring in through the green channel, net outflow on precious metals and stones comfortably exceeds gold jewellery exports. Had India not imported so much gold, it would have been a current account surplus nation.

In the first 25 years of this century alone, net gold imports totalled around \$507bn, which is more than the net FDI or FPI India received in this period.

On average, the country imports about 1,000 tonnes of gold annually and exports roughly 300 tonnes, resulting in persistent net imports of 700 tonnes. This demand keeps international prices elevated and drains foreign exchange reserves at a time when India's economy needs every dollar for productive investment.

Last year net FDI and FPI flows (combined) turned negative and put pressure on the rupee. A capital-starved nation cannot sustain high growth while effectively exporting its savings.

We must ask, when the world's largest buyer of gold decides to sell, who will buy and at what price? Today's global context offers a narrow but powerful window of opportunity. Central banks purchased 3,500 tonnes of gold in the last four years, pushing gold prices higher. Monetising just 10% of India's holdings would match that entire volume.

It's time to convert our frozen savings into a strategic strength. To this end, here are four out-of-the-box ideas.

● First, physical gold can be digitised to provide liquidity, while positioning India as a leader in the emerging world of tokenised assets. Indian institutions should launch a gold-backed crypto with UPI-level settlement efficiency, fully backed by physical gold held in Indian custody. They can also introduce gold-backed stablecoins where gold price movement remains with the issuer. Such instruments would attract foreign flows while keeping gold within the country.

El Salvador-based Tether has around \$3bn in AUM. We should empower our institutions to target \$30bn AUM, offering a credible hard-asset backed alternative to Bitcoin and other cryptos.

● Second, a revamped Gold Monetisation Scheme. Past efforts suffered from design flaws that led to low uptake. A new version must draw lessons from

their existing borrowing costs. RBI should be instructed to hedge the liability by purchasing equivalent gold internationally from its FX reserves. This gold, instead of lying in private *tijoris*, would bolster RBI's FX reserves. On maturity, RBI can sell the gold and transfer any mark-to-market gains to govt as dividends. These bonds should be issued at international dollar parity prices to make them attractive.

Investors would effectively receive about 18.45% more gold through these bonds, as import duty and GST would not apply. They would also gain protection against future import duty reductions and rupee depreciation via dollar-parity settlement.

● Fourth, a well-structured Gold Disclosure Scheme. This can bring in necessary tax revenues for a govt walking a tightrope on fiscal prudence, especially because of the West Asia war and the eighth pay commission.

This scheme's success will depend on both push and pull factors. Push through simplicity, jeweller-led trust-based outreach, and flexible options tailored to different needs. Pull through a first-come, first-served structure with limited quantum, and a minimum 10-year cooling-off period. Taxpayers could either pay an upfront tax or exchange their gold for "Viksit Bharat Bonds". Such issuance should be at global/dollar parity price. GOI will have to commit that such disclosure will have immunity from all regulatory proceedings.

These measures are not isolated fixes, but an integrated strategy. Govt gains through lower borrowing costs and maintaining fiscal prudence. RBI strengthens FX reserves and rupee stability. Households obtain liquidity and superior risk protection. Jewellers benefit from formal business growth and lower cost of gold mobilisation. Most importantly, the nation reduces its dependence on foreign capital and enhances economic sovereignty.

A high-level task force involving RBI, finmin, tax practitioners, and jewellers should be constituted to work out the nuances. Pilots should be launched with clear timelines, to test these ideas. Some may fail, some may succeed, but we must be willing to experiment. India doesn't lack capital or imagination. But it's poor at risk-taking. The best time to experiment was yesterday but better late than never.

The writer is Managing Director, Kotak Mahindra Asset Management. Views are personal

Assam Floods: Engineering A Solution

Overflowing Brahmaputra is not a disaster, but poor planning, ageing infra, and shrinking drainage make it one. Predictive infra management, rather than periodic repair, is the solution

Siddharth Roy

Assam's floods are often described as inevitable. From a civil engineer's perspective, that is an incomplete diagnosis. Brahmaputra and its tributaries will overflow during extreme monsoon events, but flooding becomes a disaster when intense hydrological forces meet vulnerable settlements, ageing infra, inadequate drainage, and poorly planned development. This year's floods have once again exposed this gap between the natural behaviour of rivers and the way humans have engineered the landscape around them.

As of Aug 15, the flood death toll had reached 104, with nearly 1.4L people still affected across seven districts. Earlier in the season, the crisis had affected more than 7L people, particularly in Upper Assam, including Sivasagar, Charaideo, and Jorhat. The numbers are staggering, but they should not be viewed simply as another annual disaster statistic. They should be treated as evidence that Assam needs a fundamental redesign of its flood-resilience strategy.

The first engineering reality is geographical. About 31,500 sq km, or 39.6% of Assam's geographical area, is classified as flood-prone – almost four times the national proportion. The state records an average annual flood-affected area of about 9.3L hectares. River erosion is an equally formidable problem: approximately 4.3L hectares have been eroded since 1950, at an average rate of about 5,600 hectares annually.

No embankment network can make such a landscape completely flood-proof.

For decades, Assam's flood-management architecture has relied heavily on embankments. They remain necessary for protecting densely populated areas and critical infra, but they cannot be treated as permanent barriers against rivers. Overtopping, seepage, piping, toe erosion, bank migration, and foundation instability can all compromise them. The state's own water resources department identifies overtopping and bank erosion among the causes of embankment breaches.

The engineering response must, therefore, move from periodic repair to predictive infra management.

Every major embankment should have a digital structural-health record covering its age, design parameters, crest elevation, soil characteristics, drainage structures, previous breaches, and vulnerable stretches. Drone surveys, satellite imagery, LiDAR, and ground sensors can identify deformation, seepage, and erosion before failure. Assam already uses GIS and satellite-based mapping; the next step should be converting these datasets into an early warning and maintenance system.

The second priority is river morphology. Brahmaputra is not a fixed channel. It is a highly dynamic, sediment-laden braided river. Its banks migrate and channels shift. Treating every erosion site with the same concrete solution can merely transfer the problem downstream. Anti-erosion measures should, therefore, follow detailed reach-wise



morphological studies. Depending on local conditions, engineers can deploy geotextiles, launching aprons, guide bunds, spurs, and bioengineering techniques while allowing controlled river migration where human assets are not immediately threatened.

The third issue is floodplain management. Engineering cannot compensate for inappropriate land use. Hospitals, schools, electrical substations, warehouses, and housing should not be permitted in high-risk zones without rigorous flood-risk assessments. Where critical infra must remain in vulnerable areas, its plinths, electrical systems, access roads, and evacuation facilities should be designed for flood conditions.

Urban Assam requires a separate strategy. Guwahati's recurring waterlogging is aggravated by wetland loss,

rapid construction, impervious surfaces, and blocked natural drainage. The solution is not simply bigger drains. Cities need interconnected stormwater networks, retention ponds, restored wetlands, permeable surfaces, and strict protection of natural drainage channels.

Climate change makes these reforms urgent. Designing infra solely from historical rainfall records is increasingly risky, when extreme precipitation patterns are changing. Updated rainfall intensity-duration-frequency curves and climate projections should inform the design of bridges, culverts, roads, drainage systems, and flood-control structures.

Tech can also transform preparedness. Real-time river gauges, satellite rainfall data, and hydrological models can provide location-specific warnings. Assam's PANEE application, which allows citizens to report embankment erosion, points towards a useful model of community-assisted infra monitoring. Such reports should feed directly into district control rooms and trigger defined inspection protocols.

But engineering solutions must also recognise the ecological role of floods. Wetlands store excess water, rivers transport sediment, and seasonal inundation sustains ecosystems. The objective cannot be to "defeat" Brahmaputra. It must be to reduce the destructive consequences of its natural behaviour.

That requires a shift from flood control to flood resilience.

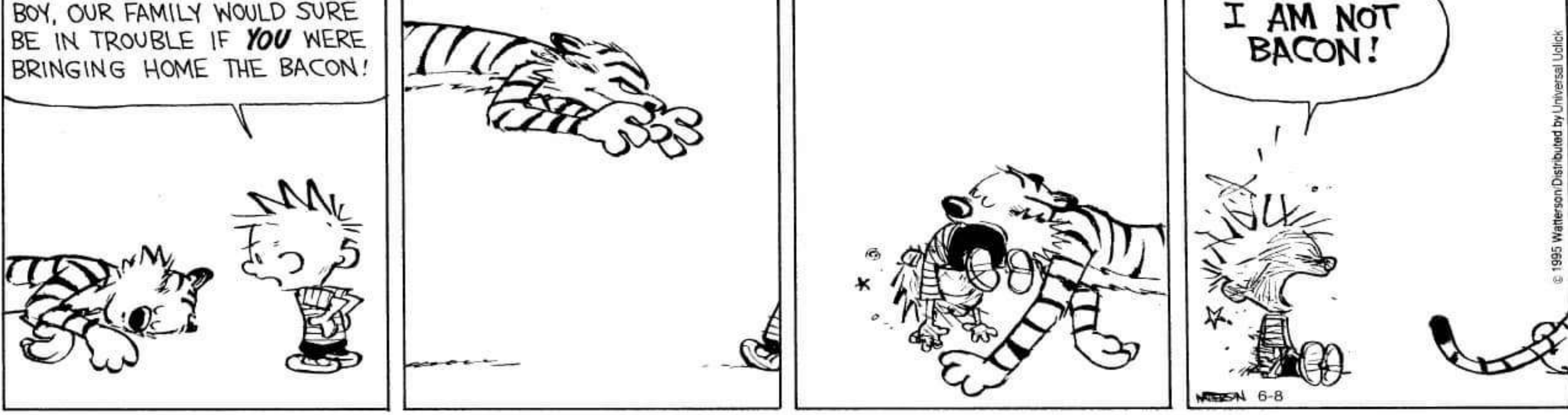
Assam should establish a long-term, independently audited flood-resilience programme, combining river science, structural engineering, land-use regulation, wetland restoration, climate modelling, and community participation. Infra projects should be evaluated not merely on construction cost, but on their lifecycle resilience and failure risk.

The 2026 floods should, therefore, be treated as an engineering warning, not merely a humanitarian emergency. Assam cannot prevent every flood. But it can reduce exposure, strengthen infra, preserve natural buffers, and anticipate failure before it becomes a catastrophe.

Brahmaputra will continue to rise. The question is whether Assam's infra will continue to fall with it. The answer should be no.

The writer is a civil engineer

Calvin & Hobbes



Gurudev Sri Sri Ravi Shankar

Can you ever be alone when you have a guru? The moment a soul is born on this planet, relationships begin. Before birth, you are unmanifest. You are pure spirit. The moment you are born, you have a mother and a father. Then all the other relationships follow.

Where does the guru stand among them? Our scriptures say, "Guru maatru pita guru bandhu sakha", meaning the guru is the mother and father. The guru gives you a second birth. He delivers you into a new world and gives you a new relationship with yourself, with the Divine and with the whole creation. The guru is mother, father, friend, companion and guide. When you have a guru, you can never be an orphan.

The loneliness that people experience disappears when they realise that the guru

is their *sakha*, their eternal friend. The guru fills whatever may be lacking in every other relationship. Every worldly relationship has its limitations. Sometimes it becomes sweeter, and sometimes it turns sour. At times, your relationship with your father or mother goes wrong. The same can happen with one's children and with one's spouse.

But take one step forward. Move beyond all these relationships and ask yourself, 'What is my relationship with myself? Who am I to myself?' That is your relationship with the guru.

Who you are to yourself is what you are to the guru. A spoonful of sugar is limited. But when it dissolves in a glass of water, it expands and becomes one with the whole. In the same way, when the individual self dissolves into wisdom, it

becomes free. The guru is love.

People often ask, 'How do I open my heart?' This very effort to open the heart creates more confusion. There is nothing to be done. You already are love. When you have a guru, you do not crave liberation. Having a guru itself is freedom. If you notice closely, the human mind is always looking for someone to lead it. Life is full of choices, and choices can become a burden.

People come to me with so many questions. I simply tell them, 'The choice is yours. The blessing is mine.' The guru is a unique leader. He leads silently, from behind, without asserting his leadership. He gives you the freedom to choose yet takes away the burden of choosing. Without inner silence, every choice becomes difficult. That is why the word 'nath' means

Sacredspace

Laughing at the universe liberated my life. I escape its weight by laughing. I refuse any intellectual translations of this laughter, since my slavery would commence from that point on.

Georges Bataille

What Is Your Relationship With Guru?



leads silently, from behind, without asserting his leadership. He gives you the freedom to choose yet takes away the burden of choosing. Without inner silence, every choice becomes difficult. That is why the word 'nath' means

‘When I was 14 days old, my father buried me and left me to die’

It was thanks to her grandfather that **Sunita Aralikar** escaped death as an infant, nearly 70 years ago. Now a campaigner against female infanticide, she recounts the story of her life

They prepared my mother’s body for cremation, and waited. She had died suddenly. After giving birth to me, she had returned to work almost immediately — a family struggling for every meal had little choice. One day, while plastering the house with cow dung, she began throwing up. Before anyone understood what was happening, she was gone.

I was 13 days old. My father had abandoned my pregnant mother, and she had returned to her family in Lodga, a village in what is now Maharashtra’s Latur district.

My grandfather — Dada, as I would call him — sent word of her death and waited for my father. He did not come.

How long could they wait for the dead woman’s husband, the villagers asked. Eventually, they cremated my mother beside a stream. Dada remained there long after everyone else had gone. Heavy rain flooded the stream that night. When he returned the next morning, water was rushing over the cremation ground. “God himself has swept away my child’s ashes,” he said.

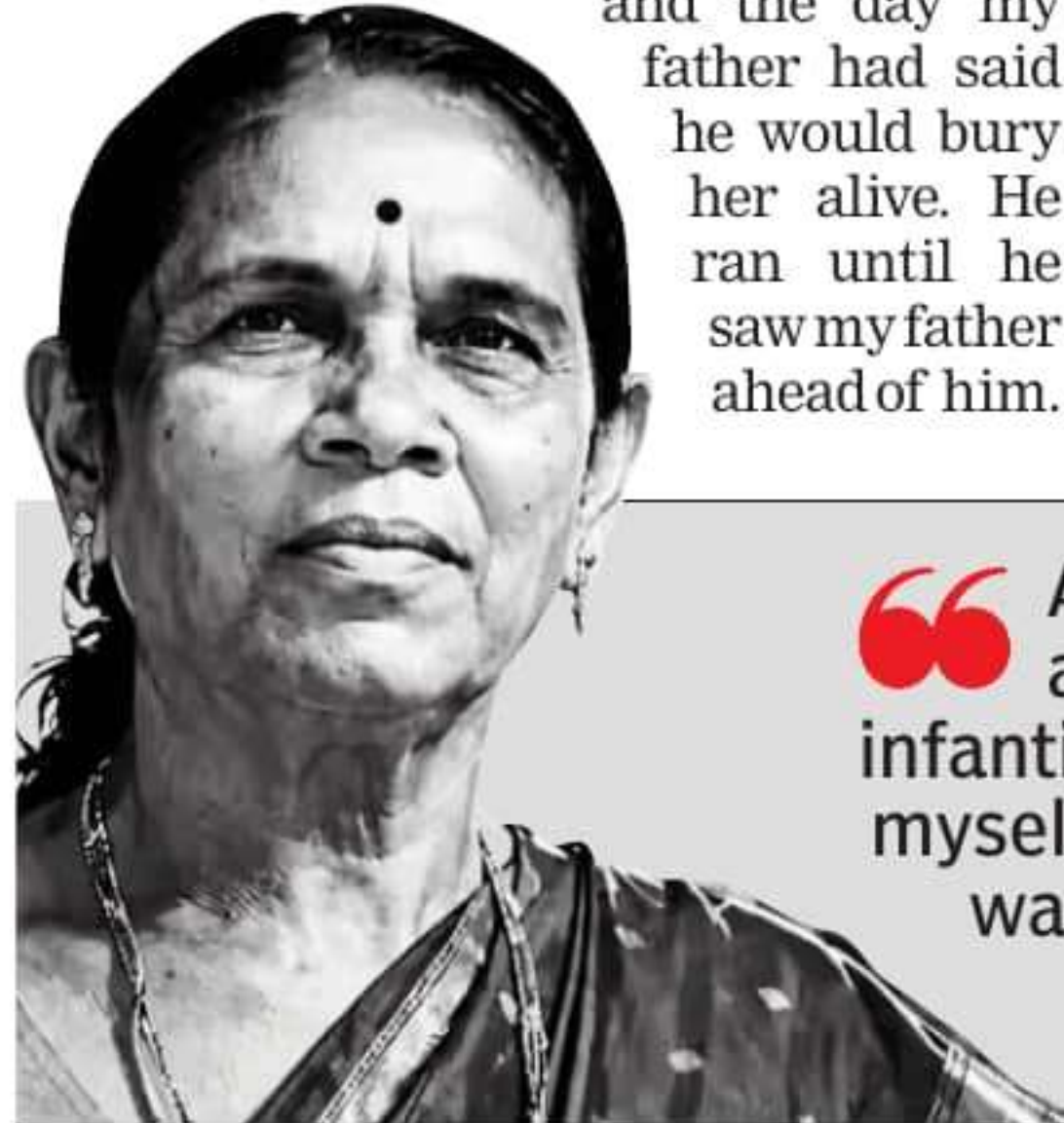
My father and his relatives arrived the following day, in a mood to quarrel.

“I cremated my daughter yesterday,” Dada told my paternal grandfather: “Take your son’s child and leave.”

I lay nearby, wrapped in a rag. When I began crying, my paternal grandmother said I had been born only to devour my mother. Why had they not put me on the pyre with her, she asked, and spared both families the burden?

Dada was broken. At least take responsibility for your child, he told my father. My father picked me up and walked away in a huff.

Then fear seized Dada. He remembered the beatings and threats during my mother’s pregnancy, and the day my father had said he would bury her alive. He ran until he saw my father ahead of him.



AI image

His hands were empty. Dada searched beside the road. Near the stream where my mother had been cremated, he noticed a shallow pit and began digging with his hands.

Beneath the soil, still wrapped in the rag, he found me.

He cleared my face and held a finger beneath my nose.

I was breathing.

I Know My Story From Those Who Saved Me
A couple of months ago, I read a newspaper report about infanticide in India. At first, I saw myself in its figures. Then I realised I was not there. What happened to me was never reported.

What happened to me was never reported. There was no police complaint or official record that a newborn girl had been buried and found alive. Had Dada been late by even two minutes, my death might not have been counted either.

I know my story because Dada, his wife Chandrabhaga and people in our village told it to me repeatedly as I grew up.

After pulling me out of the ground, Dada carried me home. There was no hospital nearby. My family wrapped me in a torn sari and placed me in a goat pen, where the animals’ bodies kept me warm. They fed me goat milk through a cotton wick.

Chandrabhaga had given birth to Kavera about 15 days before I was born. She hesitated when Dada asked her to breastfeed me too, but he persuaded her. She fed us both; Kavera and I were raised together.

Dada had found me alive. Now he had to keep me alive.

My Grandfather Raised Me As His Own Child
We eventually found shelter in Tupadi. Dada worked as a cobbler and leather maker and took whatever work he could find. At one point, we lived in a cattle shed. We were Dalit, and untouchability shaped where we could live, whom we could approach and how food was handed to us.

Still, Dada sent Kavera and me to school. He gave me his name: Shivkanta Kundalikrao Mane. I never used my father’s name or surname.

I studied after finishing the work waiting at home, and teachers who knew my circumstances helped me continue. But the nearest secondary school was in Kotal Shivani — the village where my father lived and my mother had spent

her married life.

So, to continue my education, I had to leave the man who had saved me and live with the man who had tried to kill me.

Another Attempt To Kill Me
I stayed with my father for one academic year. His family barely spoke to me. My stepmother treated me as a servant, resented my books and once tried to burn them.

There I understood what my mother had endured: overwork, hunger and be-

atings. Seven months pregnant, she was tied with a cattle rope, stripped and driven out after being threatened with burial. When she tried to stop my father from marrying again, he pushed her onto her stomach.

One day, my stepmother gave me a bhakri that tasted wrong. I ran with it to

social movements. During the drought of 1972, Dileep and I organised relief and documented people’s hardships. That Aug, police opened fire on a procession. Two people were killed. I was on duty when the injured arrived. What I saw pulled me into public life.

Our home became the Latur office of

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May 2026, Delhi | School-van driver kills his 10-month-old daughter, hides body, and reports kidnapping, citing inability to raise second daughter

Sept 2025, Shahjahanpur | 15-day-old girl buried alive; she’s rescued but dies from infection

Nov 2024, Sambhal | Newborn girl narrowly survives after being buried in field and rescued

June 2024, Delhi | A man allegedly kills and buries newborn twin daughters because he wanted a son

Aug 2022, Gujarat | Newborn girl dies after being found buried alive; parents cite poverty and preference for a son

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Dada, and we believed it had been poisoned. Yet I returned, because there was nowhere else from which I could attend school. Villagers warned me never to eat anything prepared only for me.

At the end of the year, I left. Dada rented a place where Kavera and I could study, and some teachers helped support us.

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KATE DOUGLASS BREAKS 50M FREESTYLE WORLD RECORD TWICE IN A DAY AT PAN PACIFIC C'SHIPS

LIONEL MESSI MISSES ANOTHER PENALTY AND GETS A BOOKING AS MIAMI LOSE TO NASHVILLE



TIGERS ARE DARWIN'S FITTEST

Bangladesh Leave Oz Gasping For Survival With Historic Test Win

Darwin: Bangladesh completed a stunning nine-wicket victory over Australia in the first Test on Sunday, securing their first win on Australian soil and only their second victory over top-ranked Australia.

After making a vital half-century with the bat, Mehidy Hasan Miraz took five wickets for Bangladesh in the second innings to restrict Australia to a lead of just 56 runs, as the hosts were bowled out for 284 midway through the afternoon session at Darwin's Marrara Oval.

Bangladesh suffered some early nerves in the chase when Josh Hazlewood (1-5) dismissed first-innings centurion Tanzid Hasan for a duck, but Shadman Islam (25 not out) and Mominul Haque (30 not out) held their composure to reach the target in 14.2 overs sparking wild celebrations within the contingent of Bangladesh fans seated behind the team's dugout on the boundary.

The victory was celebrated back home, too, with Shanto taking a congratulatory video call from Bangladesh prime minister Tarique Rahman in the dressing room.

Cameron Green scored his third Test century, and his first in Australia, making a composed 104 from 201 balls to lead Australia's resistance.

It was a thoroughly deserved result for Bangladesh, who had outplayed Australia for much of the Test after home captain Pat Cummins won the toss and elected to bat.

For Australia, the defeat will rank as one of their most humiliating home reverses in its 149-year Test history with considerable pressure now on the team's selectors to make changes ahead of the second test in Mackay, Queensland state, starting Aug 22.

Earlier, with the door still ajar for Australia at 161-4 at the start of Day 4 with Green and Alex Carey at the crease, Mehidy (5-66) firmly closed it with a superb spell either side of lunch to claim four more wickets, to accompany the huge wicket of Steve Smith late on Day 3 to turn the match decisively for Bangladesh.

The offspinner picked up Alex Carey (30) with the wicketkeeper batter expertly caught behind by his counterpart Litton Das. Miraz then produced a



MONUMENTAL: Bangladesh players pose after beating Australia in the Darwin Test

superb delivery that straightened past the bat of Beau Webster (5) and clipped the top of off stump to have Australia at 193-6, still trailing by 35 runs and with the tail exposed. Pat Cummins' (8) stay was brief as he offered a catch to Miraz at short leg to give him his third wicket of the morning. **AP Brief Scores:** Australia: 198 and 284 (Steve Smith 71, Cameron Green 104, Hasan Mahmud 6/55, Mehidy Hasan Miraz 5/66) lost to Bangladesh 426 and 57/11 by nine wickets

Cummins won't rule out changes

Darwin: Captain Pat Cummins admitted Australia were outplayed and refused to rule out making changes to the team after a shock nine-wicket loss to Bangladesh in Darwin on Sunday.

Under-pressure batsmen Jake Weatherald and Marnus Labuschagne failed, while there will be questions over whether they can afford to have all-rounders Beau Webster and Cameron Green both in the team.

"It's pretty clear it's not quite functioning as well as we'd like as a group, so I'm sure the batters will get together and talk,"

said Cummins.

"It's one Test but it's also a little bit of a trend as well," Cummins said about the batting issues at the top of the order. "So it's trying to work out, do you need to intervene now or do you let it play out and you think it's the way forward? So I think that's the question over the next couple of days that we'll sit down and have a think about."

"Is there something there that's going to take us forward, or is it something that's starting to become a trend that we think needs to be changed." AGENCIES



Shanto says focus on pace reaping rewards

Melbourne: Bangladesh captain Najmul Hossain Shanto said the nation's belated focus on pace is yielding rewards.

Shanto said there had been a mindset shift among the nation's young fast bowlers. "Earlier, five years ago, pacers didn't want to play Tests," Shanto said pitch-side. "But we've been playing lots of Test cricket and they are giving importance to Test format. They want to play, want to perform, want to be world-class. That is the mindset they now have."

"Seniors like Mushfiqur (Rahim) and Mominul (Haque) have encouraged them to play more Test cricket."

Bangladesh's 26-year-old fast bowler Hasan Mahmud earned the Player of the Match award after taking nine wickets, including 6-55 in the first innings on a docile pitch.

Mahmud said Bangladesh believed in themselves, de-

"This is, I think, the biggest achievement for Bangladesh cricket in Test matches. It was something we dreamed of but perhaps none of us expected Bangladesh to dominate and win like this."

—Akram Khan

FORMER BANGLADESH CAPTAIN

spite a shaky buildup that included being bowled out for 54 in a practice match just over a week ago against a Cricket Australia XI. "We got some team plans with the coaches, watching videos, and that's what we did at the ground," he said of plans for each Australian batter.

"The bowlers were patient, they stuck on the line and length. Results came."

"Going forward, we want to do something special in the future," said Shanto. REUTERS

INDIA SURGE AHEAD DESPITE TURN & RAIN

Visitors Finish Truncated Day Two On 460/9 As Spin Comes Into Play

Gaurav.Gupta@timesofindia.com

Finding their bite a tad late, Sri Lanka's spinners finally showed up in the first Test against India at the Galle International Cricket Stadium, with the 'King of Galle', left-arm spinner Prabath Jayasuriya (4-109 in 39 overs), and debutant off-spinner Keshara Nuwantha (3-175 in 39 overs) sharing all seven wickets to fall.

On a heavily rain-curtailed Day Two, with only 43 overs possible, India lost seven wickets for 172 runs but still reached a comfortable 460-9, thanks largely to a fluent 51 (68b, 4x4, 1x6) from Dhruv Jurel. It was



STEADY KNOCK: Dhruv Jurel celebrates his half-century

the wicketkeeper-batter's second Test half-century and his first in eight innings. The centrepiece of India's innings, though, was Devdutt Padikkal's elegant 167 (230b, 15x4, 1x6), the fourth-highest Test score by an Indian batter in Sri Lanka.

Jurel, who came in as a wicketkeeper-batter but is play-

INDIA IN SRI LANKA

ing as a specialist batter, has for now justified the team management's decision to pick him ahead of injury replacement Sarfaraz Khan.

Ideally, India would like to declare overnight and unleash their pacers in search of early wickets on Day Three, especially after considerable time has already been lost to bad weather,

167 Devdutt Padikkal is the third Indian to post a 150+ score at No. 3 against Sri Lanka. The other two are Rahul Dravid (177 in Ahmedabad in Nov 2009) and Cheteshwar Pujara (153 in Galle in July 2017).

which is expected to affect the remainder of the Test.

Play began only at 2.35pm after showers, but Sri Lanka bounced back superbly with the new ball after an ordinary opening day. They took three wickets for 76 runs in 21 overs before tea, with India at 364-5 after resuming at 288-2. The hosts then claimed four more wickets in the final session, conceding 96 runs in 23 overs.

Bowling slightly quicker through the air, the Sri Lankan spinners finally extracted more from the slow surface and reaped the rewards after

having bowled 78 overs without much success.

Resuming on 131, Padikkal completed his maiden Test 150 off 215 balls with a lofted flick over mid-wicket off pacer Asitha Fernando. His long vigil ended when he was stumped off Jayasuriya, who held his length back after seeing the left-hander charge down the track.

India's day began on a wrong note when Rishabh Pant (39, 62b, 4x4, 1x6) stepped out and miscued a flighted delivery from Nuwantha to deepish mid-off, where Sonal Dinusha took the catch. It was Nuwantha's maiden Test wicket.

Rahul, who had retired hurt on 77 with cramps on Saturday, resumed after Pant's dismissal but added only five runs before falling to Nuwantha. After tea, Ravindra Jadeja fell lbw for 13 (25b, 1x4) to Nuwantha. Jurel then kept India's innings moving.

SCOREBOARD

India 1st innings: Y Jaiswal run out 32, KL Rahul c Fernando b Nuwantha 82, D Padikkal st Dickwella b Jayasuriya 167, S Gill c Igalagamage b Jayasuriya 16, R Pant c Dinusha b Nuwantha 39, D Jurel c de Silva b Jayasuriya 51, R Jadeja lbw b Nuwantha 13, M Suthar c Igalagamage b Jayasuriya 24, M Siraj c de Silva b Fernando 11, K Yadav batting 12, P Krishna batting 1; **Extras: (b4, lb3, nb3, w1) 12; Total: (9 wkts in 116 overs) 460; FoW:** 1-47, 2-236, 3-307, 4-319, 5-357, 6-377, 7-432, 8-447, 9-447; **Bowling:** Fernando 17-1-61-1, Kumara 13-1-76-0 Nuwantha 39-1-175-3, Jayasuriya 39-6-109-4, de Silva 4-0-15-0, Dinusha 4-0-17-0.

'Stint with India A in SL helped my batting'

Gaurav.Gupta@timesofindia.com

Coming into the first Test against Sri Lanka in Galle, pressure was mounting on Dhruv Jurel. The 25-year-old had failed to score a fifty in his previous seven innings, raising questions over his place in the playing XI.

However, justifying the faith shown in him by the Indian team management, Jurel struck a fluent 51 off 68 balls — his second Test half-century — to help India post a formidable 460 for nine on the second day of the Galle Test.

"There was, honestly, no pressure. I am very grateful that I have the opportunity to represent India. That's the only privilege that I play for. Whenever I speak to the cap-

tain or head coach, they always tell me what to do according to the situation. So I play accordingly. There is no personal milestone that I look for before batting. I just go there and do what the team needs," Jurel said at the post-day press conference on Sunday.

Jurel said his decision to arrive in Sri Lanka early, coupled with his experience of playing at the same venue for India A in the lead-up to the Test series, stood him in good stead.

"We came here 10 days before the first Test. We practised in Colombo and, before that, played for India A. We had four-five sessions. It's all about batting on these kinds of surfaces as much as I can. It improves my batting, helps me understand the environment and the situation. So it's really helpful," he said.

GALLERY

Delhi beat Raengdai, to face EC in Durand semis

Ranchi: SC Delhi defeated Raengdai 5-1 in the first quarterfinal of the Durand Cup at the Birsu Munda Football Stadium. They will now face East Bengal in the semifinal. In Kolkata, a first-half header from PV Vishnu saw East Bengal FC edge past a spirited Indian Army FT side by a solitary goal in another quarterfinal.

Salah's Trabzonspor debut ends in draw: Mohamed Salah made his competitive debut for Trabzonspor on Saturday, coming off the bench in their Turkish Super Lig opener as Kasimpasa rallied from a goal down to secure a 1-1 draw. Trabzonspor took the lead in the first half through Noah Saviole before Kasimpasa's Adrian Benedyczak levelled from the penalty spot in the second half.

Sevilla bt Valleciano as LaLiga gets under way: Sevilla came back from a goal down to beat Rayo Valleciano 2-1 at home and Alaves beat 10-man Getafe 3-0 as LaLiga got underway.

Pranavi finishes 38th in Switzerland: Pranavi Urs finished tied-38th at the VP Bank Swiss Ladies. She carded 3 under.

Eala enters Rd 3 in Cincinnati: Alexandra Eala advanced to the third round of the Cincinnati Open 6-1, 3-0 as the injured Elena-Gabriela Ruse quit their match during a weather delay. AGENCIES

ACTION TODAY

BADMINTON: World Championships, 9 am (JioHotstar, Star); **CRICKET:** India vs Sri Lanka, 1st Test, Day 3, 10 am (Sony Sports); **FOOTBALL:** Durand Cup, QFs, Mohun Bagan vs JFC, 4 pm; Shillong Lajong vs NEUFC 7 pm (Sony); **HOCKEY:** WC, men's: India vs England, 6.30 pm, (JioHotstar, Star)

India find missing piece in Chinese puzzle

Marijne's Side Holds Olympic Silver Medallists To 2-2 Draw

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Four matches, four defeats. The Indian women's hockey team's recent record against China made the Paris Olympics silver medallists appear much formidable opponents even before the World Cup began. But on Sunday, India produced a spirited display to hold the world No. 4 side to a 2-2 draw in Amstelveen. With the Asian Games looming in five week's time, this verdict would count as a victory despite the split points.

Taking the lead as early as in the eighth minute through a field goal from Navneet



FINDING HER WAY: India's Deepika dodges past Chinese defenders

Kaur, India were determined to take the fight to the Chinese team from the start.

China may have equalised in the dying seconds of the first quarter through a penalty stroke, but that didn't hold India back and they continued to attack, winning their second penalty corner in the second quarter, which Deepika duly converted. India could have even

scored a third within minutes, but Lalremliam failed to deflect Navneet's pass from close range. It would prove a costly miss as China, playing a 4-4-2 formation, stepped up the pressure in the third quarter. Despite some brilliant defending by Nikki Pradhan & Co. and superb saves by Savita Punia, China restored parity when Ning Ma scored from a

penalty corner in the 39th minute. In the fourth quarter, India still had opportunities to snatch the win but could not convert them. They were also unlucky not to be awarded a penalty corner in the dying moments of the game. Bichu Devi Kharibam, meanwhile, made some crucial saves to ensure India at least came away with a point.

"We tried our best and played really well. It's a learning experience for us for the next matches," Navneet, who had an exceptional game, said afterwards. Not only did she score the opener, but she also created chances all game and dropped back to aid the defence. India will next take on South Africa on Tuesday and will hope to secure a big win to ensure they remain in contention for the second round.



Young India have task cut out against England

Manuja.Veerappa@timesofindia.com

In the current men's hockey team, if one looks for players born before 1994, you will find only two — Manpreet Singh and Amit Rohidas. A young side, barring the two veterans, none of the others were even born the last time India defeated England in a World Cup contest. Monday's meeting then must count as a unique first.

That victory came with 288 points, edging Porsche (271). DS PENSKE's Taylor Barnard (42:19.363) won the frantic finale after a phenomenal drive from P6. The 21-year-old held off Mahindra duo Nyck de Vries and Edoardo Mortara to become the youngest-ever Formula E race

face the world No. 3 side on Monday. India have, however, ticked a few boxes against England in recent times, the biggest being their quarterfinal victory at the Paris Olympics.

India opened their World Cup campaign with a 3-1 victory over Wales on Saturday, while England defeated Pakistan 4-1.

India could afford moments of sluggishness against Wales, but England will present a different challenge. One of the biggest positives from the opener was the coordination between the strike force and midfield.

The biggest concern was the drop in intensity during the final 10 minutes. "Since we have started playing the Pro League, it's been pretty equal. But the World Cup is different. It's a must-win game for both the teams. They are the highest-ranked team in our pool, so we are really going to go after them," he said.

Belgium's Gen Next in the spotlight

Arnab.Seal@timesofindia.com

When Belgium needed a moment of brilliance in their World Cup opener against France on Saturday, it was one of the old hands who stepped up.

Alexander Hendrickx's penalty-corner goal in the 56th minute helped Belgium edge France 3-2. But while the result offered an early reminder of the quality and experience still present in the Belgian side, this is also a team trying to build its next chapter.

The team that walked out for

this World Cup was not quite the same side that won the title in 2018 and followed it up with Olympic gold in Tokyo. A generation of senior players has moved on, with Hendrickx saying nine or 10 players retired after the Paris Olympics.

In their place has come a younger group being asked to carry forward the standards established by the golden generation.

"It's always difficult to get that collective work to click perfectly straight away," captain Arthur van Doren said in the build-up to the tournament. "We've worked quite

hard on that, and we're now in a very good state of mind." The transition, however, has not meant abandoning the identity that has made Belgium one of the world's leading hockey nations.

"You always adapt and evolve," added Van Doren, who plays for Kalinga Lancers in the Hockey India League. Hendrickx, who has been at the heart of Belgium's success for more than a decade, meanwhile sees the younger generation bringing something different from the team. "They're learning quickly and they're quite physical," he said.

Mahindra Racing finish third

Neha.Surana@timesofindia.com

London: Mahindra Racing signed off their Formula E 2026 campaign in style. They secured a historic first-ever front-row lockout, with Nyck de Vries and Edoardo Mortara starting from the front in the Formula E's London E-Prix race here at the demanding Excel Circuit on Sunday.

Nyck (42:19:977) and Mortara (42:25:450) then delivered a double podium, finishing second and third respectively.

The result lifted Mahindra to third in the Teams' Championship with 252 points. It also earned the Indian manufacturer its first podium finish in nearly a decade. Jaguar clinched the Teams' Championship with 288 points, edging Porsche (271).

DS PENSKE's Taylor Barnard (42:19.363) won the frantic finale after a phenomenal drive from P6. The 21-year-old held off Mahindra duo Nyck de Vries and Edoardo Mortara to become the youngest-ever Formula E race

Wehrlein champion

Pascal Wehrlein clinched his second Formula E world title despite finishing outside the points. The Porsche driver was classified 14th after a dramatic race, but had done enough over the weekend to hold on to the Drivers' Championship.



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Overnight strikes killed 12 people in Russia and Ukraine, authorities say, as waves of drones & missiles pummel infra on both sides, OTHER BK, INSIDE JKT

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Initial public offer of equity shares on the main board platform of BSE Limited ("BSE") and National Stock Exchange of India Limited ("NSE", and together with BSE, the "Stock Exchanges") in compliance with Chapter II of the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Issue of Capital and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2018, as amended ("SEBI ICDR Regulations").



(Please scan this QR Code to view the RHP and Abridged Prospectus)



LALITHAA JEWELLERY MART LIMITED (TO BE LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARD OF BSE AND NSE)

Our Company was incorporated under the name of "Lalitha Jewellery Mart Private Limited", as a private limited company under the Companies Act, 1956, pursuant to a certificate of incorporation dated November 26, 1985, issued by the Registrar of Companies, Tamil Nadu & Andaman at Chennai ("RoC"). Subsequently, the name of our Company was changed from "Lalitha Jewellery Mart Private Limited" to "Lalithaa Jewellery Mart Private Limited" pursuant to a fresh certificate of incorporation consequent upon change of name, dated November 4, 2013, issued by the Registrar of Companies, Tamil Nadu & Andaman at Chennai. Subsequently, our Company was converted from a private limited company into a public company pursuant to the Board resolution dated November 23, 2023 and the special resolution dated December 18, 2023 passed by our Shareholders and consequently the name of our Company was changed to "Lalithaa Jewellery Mart Limited" and a fresh certificate of incorporation dated January 5, 2024 was issued by the RoC. For further details of change in name of our Company, please refer to the section titled "History and Certain Corporate Matters" on page 280 of the Red Herring Prospectus dated August 9, 2026 ("RHP") filed with the RoC.

Corporate Identity Number: U36911TN1985PLC012417

Registered Office: 123, Usman Road T. Nagar, Chennai – 600017, Tamil Nadu, India. Corporate Office: ICON Savitri Ganesh No.53, Habibullah Road, T. Nagar, Chennai – 600017, Tamil Nadu, India.

Contact Person: Jitendra Kumar Pal, Company Secretary and Compliance Officer; E-mail: cosec@lalithaajewellery.com; Telephone: +044 2834 9860; Website: www.lalithaajewellery.com

OUR PROMOTERS: M. KIRAN KUMAR JAIN AND HEMAA KIRAN KUMAR JAIN

INITIAL PUBLIC OFFER OF UP TO [•] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹5 EACH ("EQUITY SHARES") OF LALITHAA JEWELLERY MART LIMITED (THE "COMPANY") FOR CASH AT A PRICE OF ₹[•] PER EQUITY SHARE (INCLUDING A SHARE PREMIUM OF ₹[•] PER EQUITY SHARE) ("OFFER PRICE") AGGREGATING UP TO ₹17,000 MILLION ("OFFER"). THE OFFER COMPRISES A FRESH ISSUE OF UP TO [•] EQUITY SHARES AGGREGATING UP TO ₹12,000 MILLION BY OUR COMPANY (THE "FRESH ISSUE") AND AN OFFER FOR SALE OF UP TO [•] EQUITY SHARES ("OFFERED SHARES") AGGREGATING UP TO ₹5,000 MILLION BY M. KIRAN KUMAR JAIN (THE "PROMOTER SELLING SHAREHOLDER", AND SUCH OFFER FOR SALE OF EQUITY SHARES BY THE PROMOTER SELLING SHAREHOLDER, THE "OFFER FOR SALE"). THE OFFER WILL CONSTITUTE [•]% OF THE POST-OFFER PAID UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL OF OUR COMPANY. THIS OFFER INCLUDES A RESERVATION OF UP TO [•] EQUITY SHARES AGGREGATING UP TO ₹60.00 MILLION (CONSTITUTING UP TO [•]% OF THE POST-OFFER PAID-UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL OF OUR COMPANY) FOR SUBSCRIPTION BY ELIGIBLE EMPLOYEES (THE "EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION"). OUR COMPANY, IN CONSULTATION WITH THE BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS, MAY OFFER A DISCOUNT OF UP TO 10 % (EQUIVALENT OF ₹19 PER EQUITY SHARE) TO THE OFFER PRICE TO ELIGIBLE EMPLOYEES BIDDING UNDER THE EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION ("EMPLOYEE DISCOUNT"). THE OFFER LESS THE EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION IS HEREINAFTER REFERRED TO AS THE "NET OFFER". THE OFFER AND THE NET OFFER SHALL CONSTITUTE [•]% AND [•]%, RESPECTIVELY OF THE POST-OFFER PAID-UP EQUITY SHARE CAPITAL OF OUR COMPANY.

DETAILS OF THE OFFER FOR SALE BY THE PROMOTER SELLING SHAREHOLDER			
NAME OF THE SELLING SHAREHOLDER	TYPE	NUMBER OF SHARES OFFERED/ AMOUNT (IN ₹ MILLION)	WEIGHTED AVERAGE COST OF ACQUISITION PER EQUITY SHARE (IN ₹)*
M. Kiran Kumar Jain	Promoter Selling Shareholder	Up to [•] Equity Shares of face value ₹ 5 aggregating up to ₹ 5,000 million	3.51

*As certified by the R.K. Chapawat & Co., Chartered Accountants, by way of their certificate dated August 9, 2026.

PRICE BAND: ₹190 TO ₹201 PER EQUITY SHARE OF FACE VALUE OF ₹5 EACH.

THE FLOOR PRICE IS 38.00 TIMES THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹5 EACH AND THE CAP PRICE IS 40.20 TIMES THE FACE VALUE OF THE EQUITY SHARES.

BIDS CAN BE MADE FOR A MINIMUM OF 74 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹5 EACH AND IN MULTIPLES OF 74 EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹5 EACH THEREAFTER.

THE PRICE TO EARNINGS RATIO ("P/E") BASED ON DILUTED EPS FOR FINANCIAL YEAR ENDED 2026 FOR THE COMPANY AT THE UPPER END (I.E. CAP PRICE) OF THE PRICE BAND IS 9.95 TIMES AND AT THE LOWER END (I.E. FLOOR PRICE) OF THE PRICE BAND IS 9.41 TIMES AS COMPARED TO THE AVERAGE INDUSTRY PEER GROUP P/E RATIO OF 29.69 TIMES FOR FISCAL 2026.

WEIGHTED AVERAGE RETURN ON NETWORTH FOR LAST THREE FISCAL YEARS IS 30.55%.

A DISCOUNT OF ₹19 PER EQUITY SHARE OF ₹5 EACH IS BEING OFFERED TO ELIGIBLE EMPLOYEES BIDDING IN THE EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION.

The details of the Fresh Issue, Offer for Sale and the post Offer market capitalization of the Company, each at the Floor Price and the Cap Price, are given below:

Particulars	OFFER SIZE AND MARKET CAPITALIZATION			
	At Floor Price of ₹190 per equity share		At Cap Price of ₹201 per equity share	
	Up to No. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹5 each	Up to Amount (₹ in Million)	Up to No. of Equity Shares of face value of ₹5 each	Up to Amount (₹ in Million)
Fresh Issue	63,192,982	12,000.00^	59,732,655	12,000.00^
Offer For Sale	26,315,789	5,000.00	24,875,621	5,000.00
Total Offer Size	89,508,771	17,000.00	84,608,276	17,000.00
Post Offer Market Capitalization*	563,170,138	106,995.66	559,709,811	112,495.41

*Market capitalisation is computed as the total equity shares outstanding post Offer by the upper and lower ends of the Price Band, as applicable. | ^The Offer includes Employee Reservation Portion and a discount of ₹19 per Equity Share is being offered to the Eligible Employees bidding in the Employee Reservation Portion. The amount is after the adjustment of the number of equity shares to be allotted in the Employee Reservation Portion at the Employee Discount.

BID/ OFFER PERIOD	BID/ OFFER OPENS TODAY
	BID/ OFFER CLOSES ON WEDNESDAY, AUGUST 19, 2026*

*UPI mandate end time and date shall be at 5:00 p.m. on the Bid/ Offer Closing Date.

We are a jewellery retailer operating under the brand name "Lalithaa", primarily selling diverse range of gold jewellery along with other offerings including silver and diamond jewellery across styles, designed to cater to regional preferences of the southern Indian jewellery markets.

THE OFFER IS BEING MADE THROUGH THE BOOK BUILDING PROCESS IN ACCORDANCE WITH REGULATION 6(1) OF THE SEBI ICDR REGULATIONS 2018.

THE EQUITY SHARES OF THE COMPANY WILL GET LISTED ON THE MAIN BOARDS OF BSE LIMITED AND NATIONAL STOCK EXCHANGE OF INDIA LIMITED. BSE LIMITED SHALL BE THE DESIGNATED STOCK EXCHANGE.

• QIB PORTION: NOT MORE THAN 50% OF THE NET OFFER • NON-INSTITUTIONAL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 15% OF THE NET OFFER

• RETAIL PORTION: NOT LESS THAN 35% OF THE NET OFFER • EMPLOYEE RESERVATION PORTION: UP TO [•] EQUITY SHARES OF FACE VALUE OF ₹5 EACH AGGREGATING UP TO ₹60.00 MILLION

IN MAKING AN INVESTMENT DECISION, POTENTIAL INVESTORS MUST RELY ONLY ON THE INFORMATION INCLUDED IN THE RHP AND THE TERMS OF THE OFFER, INCLUDING THE RISKS INVOLVED AND NOT RELY ON ANY OTHER EXTERNAL SOURCES OF INFORMATION ABOUT THE OFFER AVAILABLE IN ANY MANNER. IN RELATION TO PRICE BAND, POTENTIAL INVESTORS SHOULD ONLY REFER TO THIS PRICE BAND ADVERTISEMENT FOR THE OFFER AND SHOULD NOT RELY ON ANY MEDIA ARTICLES/ REPORTS IN RELATION TO THE VALUATION OF THE COMPANY AS THESE ARE NOT ENDORSED, PUBLISHED OR CONFIRMED EITHER BY THE COMPANY OR THE BOOK RUNNING LEAD MANAGERS TO THE OFFER ("BRLMS").

In accordance with the recommendation of a committee of Independent Directors of our Company, pursuant to their resolution dated August 10, 2026, the above provided price band is justified based on quantitative factors/ key performance indicators ("KPIs") disclosed in the "Basis for Offer Price" section on page 135 of the RHP vis-a-vis the weighted average cost of acquisition ("WACA") of primary and secondary transaction(s), as applicable, as disclosed in the "Basis for Offer Price" section beginning on the page 135 of the RHP and provided below in this advertisement.

In relation to the Price Band, potential investors should only refer to this price band advertisement for the Offer and should not rely on any media articles/ reports in relation to the valuation of our Company as these are not endorsed, published or confirmed either by the Company or by the BRLMs.

Risk to Investors

For details, refer to section titled "Risk Factors" on page 22 of the RHP.

- Revenue dependence on sale of gold jewellery:** Our revenues have been significantly dependent on sale of gold jewellery, which accounted for 92.33%, 94.58% and 93.96% of our revenue from operations, for the Financial Years 2026, 2025 and 2024, respectively. Accordingly, any factors adversely affecting our sales of gold jewellery, such as, an increase in international gold prices, higher import duties or regulatory restrictions, decline in consumer discretionary spending, shift in consumer preferences to alternatives, etc. may negatively impact our business, financial condition, results of operations and prospects.
- Negative operating cash flows in the past:** We have experienced negative cash flows from operating activities of ₹3,977.62 million and ₹180.02 million in Fiscal 2026 and in Fiscal 2024 respectively, due to lower customer enrolment towards the Company's jewellery schemes and increased settlement of trade payables and cannot assure you that we will not experience negative cash flows in future periods. Negative cash flows may adversely affect our financial condition, results of operations and prospects.

Particulars	Fiscal 2026 ₹ in million	Fiscal 2025 ₹ in million	Fiscal 2024 ₹ in million
Net cash (used in) / generated from operating activities	(3,977.62)	2,887.31	(180.02)

- Risk related to customer advances:** We receive advances from our customers under various schemes introduced by us. The amounts received in the schemes amount to more than 10% of our revenue from operations for the respective financial periods. Inability to appropriate such advances received from customers under jewellery purchase schemes may adversely impact our revenues and results of operations and future profitability.

Particulars	Financial Year ended March 31, 2026		Financial Year ended March 31, 2025		Financial Year ended March 31, 2024	
	(₹) in million	% of total revenue from operations	(₹) in million	% of total revenue from operations	(₹) in million	% of total revenue from operations
Advances from customers	50,427.50	20.15%	31,454.10	18.61%	19,432.26	11.58%

- Dependence on In-house Manufacturing and Karigars for jewellery manufacturing:** In Fiscal 2026, we operated our Manufacturing Facilities with 672 Karigars employed by our Company and 144 Karigars employed by Asita Jewellery Manufacturing Private Limited ("Asita") for manufacturing of our products. These Karigars who are on the rolls of our Company and Asita, manufactured 79.11%, 80.66% and 79.78% of our total products available for sale for Fiscal 2026, Fiscal 2025 and Fiscal 2024, respectively. Further, we have entered into short term agreements with 296 Karigars (as of March 31, 2026), on a non-exclusive basis, for manufacture and supply of jewellery. Our Company is dependent on these Karigars for manufacturing our products and any disruptions at our Manufacturing Facilities, or loss of these Karigars or failure of these Karigars to adhere to the relevant quality standards may have a negative effect on our reputation, business and financial condition.
- High working capital requirement:** Our business requires a substantial amount of working capital for operations including for financing the purchase of raw materials. We intend to continue growing by setting up new stores (including inventory requirements) and increase our focus on sale of jewellery. We may need to seek additional financing in the normal course of business from time to time as we expand our operations and any inability in obtaining such additional funds in a timely manner may adversely affect our business, growth plans, results of operations, financial condition and cash flows. The table

below sets out our working capital for the years/period set out:

Particulars	Fiscal 2026	Fiscal 2025	Fiscal 2024
Working capital requirements* (in ₹ million)	44,661.08	25,768.29	22,835.41
Revenue from operations (in ₹ million)	250,239.27	168,973.17	167,880.52
Working capital as percentage of revenue from operations	17.85%	15.25%	13.60%

*Working capital requirement is computed as sum of Inventory and trade receivables minus trade payables minus advance from customers as at the year end.

- Dependence on top three suppliers of raw materials:** We are dependent on our top three suppliers of raw materials who have contributed 58.03%, 67.20% and 66.98% in Fiscals 2026, 2025 and 2024, respectively of our total cost of raw materials. We typically procure gold through purchase orders and do not enter into any long-term agreements with our suppliers. In the event our suppliers are unable to provide us the required quantity of raw materials, or if we are unable to find alternate suppliers at commercially acceptable terms, our ability to manufacture our products in a timely manner will be adversely affected leading to an adverse impact on our business, results of operations and financial condition.
- Usage of brand "Lalithaa" and payment of Brand Ambassador fees:** Our business is significantly dependent on the reputation and awareness of our brand, "Lalithaa". Any failure to maintain our reputation, enhance our brand recognition or increase positive awareness of our products, it may be difficult to maintain and grow our consumer base, which could have a material adverse effect on our financial condition, results of operations, business and growth prospects. Further, our Promoter received brand ambassador fees of 0.30% of revenue in Fiscal 2024; this arrangement has since been terminated.
- Geographical concentration risk:** As of March 31, 2026, we operate 61 stores in 51 cities across Andhra Pradesh, Karnataka, Tamil Nadu, Telangana and Puducherry. As of March 31, 2026, we have 23 stores in Andhra Pradesh, 20 stores in Tamil Nadu, 7 in Karnataka, 10 in Telangana and 1 in Puducherry. The geographic concentration of all (100%) our stores in the southern regions of India heightens our exposure to adverse developments related to competition, economic downturn and demographic changes in these regions, which may adversely affect our business prospects, financial conditions and results of operations.
- Seasonal Fluctuation Risk:** In India, the demand of jewellery is mainly driven by weddings, festivals, birth and the harvest season. We have historically experienced certain seasonal fluctuations, reflecting higher sales volumes during festival periods and other occasions such as Akshay Tritiya, Durga Puja, Dhanteras, Diwali, Poila and Baisakh. Any slowdown in demand for our jewellery during peak seasons or failure by us to accurately anticipate and prepare for such seasonal fluctuations could have an adverse effect on our business, financial condition and results of operations.
- Competition Risk:** We operate in highly competitive and fragmented markets, and our market share may get adversely affected due to competition in these markets which is based primarily on market trends, pricing and customer preferences. We face competition from both the organized and unorganised sectors of the jewellery retail business, including online marketplaces. Competitors may have significant advantages such as stronger distribution networks, brand recall, promotional offers for customers, technical and financial capabilities. Consequently, we may not be able to compete successfully in the future against our existing or potential competitors, or we cannot assure you that our business and results of operations will not be adversely affected by increased competition in the offline and online channels.
- Risk related to jewellery designs and continuous innovation:** We have an in-house jewellery designing team of fifteen members responsible for introducing new and innovative designs for our jewellery. Our in-house design team comprises of managers and skilled professionals consisting of CAD (Computer-Aided Design) designers who work on digital design,

Continued on next page...



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माननीय प्रधानमंत्री



श्री भजनलाल शर्मा
माननीय मुख्यमंत्री

प्रगति पथ पर गतिमान राजस्थान



17 अगस्त, 2026 | प्रातः 11:30 बजे | कृषि उपज मण्डी, बारां

गरिमामयी उपस्थिति

श्री भजनलाल शर्मा

माननीय मुख्यमंत्री

श्री शिवराज सिंह चौहान

माननीय केन्द्रीय कृषि एवं किसान कल्याण तथा ग्रामीण विकास मंत्री

बारां एवं झालावाड़ जिलों के लिए

₹1,258 करोड़ के 98 विकास कार्यों का शिलान्यास एवं लोकार्पण

प्रधानमंत्री आवास योजना-ग्रामीण

राजस्थान को वित्तीय वर्ष 2026-27 के लिए 2.89 लाख आवासों के निर्माण हेतु ₹ 4600 करोड़ आवंटित

पंचायत समिति मुख्यालयों पर स्वीकृत प्रोटोटाइप आवासों का शिलान्यास

लाभार्थियों को नवीन आवास की चाबी का वितरण

विकसित भारत रोजगार गारंटी एवं आजीविका मिशन-ग्रामीण

कन्वर्जेन्स के तहत लगभग ₹2,400 करोड़ के कार्यों को युक्त धारा पोर्टल पर कार्ययोजना में सम्मिलित करना

◦ प्रमुख कार्य ◦

अमृत पोषण वाटिका | अमृत ग्रामीण हाट बाजार | ग्रामीण पुस्तकालय
अमृत संजीवनी पार्क | कांजी हाउस पशु आश्रय स्थल | नमो नर्सरी

डीबीटी के माध्यम से राशि हस्तांतरण

मुख्यमंत्री दुग्ध उत्पादक संबल योजना
5 लाख पशुपालकों को ₹280 करोड़

गौशाला अनुदान
751 गौशालाओं को ₹250 करोड़

महिला उत्थान

स्वयं सहायता समूह की दीदियों को ₹10 करोड़ के क्रेडिट लिंकेज चेक का वितरण

राजस्थान महिला निधि की लखपति दीदी ऋण योजना अंतर्गत 957 लखपति दीदियों को ₹8 करोड़ के चेक का वितरण

राजस्थान महिला निधि की समर्थ सखी योजना अंतर्गत स्वयं सहायता समूहों की दीदियों को स्कूटी वितरण

“सशक्त सीएलएफ, समृद्ध दीदी डिजिटल अभियान-2026” का शुभारंभ

ग्राम श्री राजसखी मार्ट 11.77 लाख, बारां का शुभारंभ

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